

Illegal constructions, hotels under scanner in South East Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Fresh inspections carried out by revenue authorities in South East Delhi have revealed multiple cases of unauthorised construction, fire safety violations and irregularities in hotels and buildings, according to the Revenue Department's latest inspection report dated June 7, 2026.

The report, prepared by sub-divisional authorities in Kalkaji and Jangpura, details action initiated against several properties where violations were found during

field inspections. The inspections form part of the Delhi Government's intensified crackdown on illegal constructions and safety violations following recent fire incidents in the Capital.

In the Kalkaji subdivision, officials identified four properties in the Madanpur Khadar area where unauthorised construction activity was allegedly taking place in the O Zone area.

The violations were found near Makki Masjid in Madanpur Khadar Part III. According to the report, all four sites were inspected on June, 7 and show-cause

notices were issued to the owners or occupants.

One of the properties, located behind A-70 in Khasra No. 812, was found to have a two-floor structure under unauthorised construction. Another property behind A-55 in the same Khasra number had a three-floor structure under construction.

A separate portion of Khasra No. 812 was reported to have a six-floor unauthorised structure, while another plot identified as Plot No. 12 in Khasra No. 812 had a two-floor building under construction. In all four cases, officials recorded that violations had



been found and show-cause notices were served. The report specifically noted that none of the four properties had fire NOCs. Authorities also recorded that

the constructions were taking place in the O Zone area, which is subject to strict land-use regulations.

The inspections were conducted under the supervision of the Sub-Divisional Magistrate of Kalkaji.

In a separate inspection carried out by the Jangpura subdivision, officials examined hotels operating in Lajpat Nagar-IV. Two establishments were inspected during the exercise. One hotel, Bamyam The Boutique located at 6A Ring Road, was found operating with a valid fire NOC, and no violation was recorded against it. The

five-floor hotel cleared the inspection without adverse remarks.

However, another hotel identified as Royal Comfort in Dayanand Colony was found operating without a fire NOC. Officials recorded that violations were detected at the premises, and a show-cause notice was issued. The inspection report described the property as a five-floor hotel.

According to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the government's policy on illegal construction is unambiguous. "Violations of the ground-plus-five limit and prescribed construction norms will not

be accepted under any circumstances in the capital. If any individual, builder, or institution undertakes construction in violation of the rules, strict action will be taken in accordance with the law. No one will be allowed to put people's lives at risk," she said.

The Chief Minister said the government is also working on long-term structural reforms in building safety. Among the possibilities under consideration is a third-party insurance mechanism for public-use buildings, guest houses, nursing homes, and other institutions.

Government plans to add 2,800 new electric buses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has announced plans to add 2,800 new air-conditioned low-floor electric buses to the city's public transport network under the Centre's PM E-DRIVE scheme, in one of the biggest expansions of electric mobility in the Capital.

Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh said the proposed fleet will include 1,400 nine-metre buses and 1,400 twelve-metre buses aimed at improving connectivity, strengthening feeder services, and expanding access to public transport across Delhi.

The Government said the



move is part of its larger strategy to modernise public transport infrastructure and reduce pollution caused by conventional fuel vehicles.

Officials said the induction of the new buses is expected to improve transport services in underserved and peripheral areas while also easing

travel on high-density routes.

The Transport Department has already observed strong operational performance from the nine-metre electric buses currently running in the capital, particularly on feeder and local routes. Based on that experience, the Government now plans to

build a more balanced fleet capable of handling both neighbourhood connectivity and heavy passenger traffic.

At present, Delhi operates nearly 4,300 electric buses, making it one of the largest electric bus networks in the country. According to the government, the number of electric buses in the capital is expected to rise to around 7,500 by the end of this year.

The Delhi Government has also set a long-term target of expanding the city's total public transport bus fleet to nearly 14,000 buses by 2028-29. Officials said the expansion plan is intended to improve service coverage, increase accessibility, and provide better connectivity

across all parts of the National Capital Territory.

Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said the government is also pursuing the addition of 3,330 more electric buses under PM E-DRIVE Phase II. This proposal includes 500 seven-metre electric buses that are expected to strengthen last-mile connectivity and feeder transport services in residential colonies, rural areas, and locations with limited public transport coverage.

The minister said the smaller buses would complement the larger bus network and help improve accessibility in areas where full-sized buses face operational difficulties.

Woman killed, five injured as car hits tempo on Rajokari flyover; driver held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 47-year-old woman was killed and five others, including three children, were injured after a Toyota Innova allegedly rammed into a tempo from behind on the Rajokari flyover in southwest Delhi's Vasant Kunj area early Sunday, police said.

The accident occurred at around 4.20 am on the carriageway towards Gurugram. A PCR call regarding the incident was received shortly after the crash, and local police rushed to the spot, they said.

During the preliminary



enquiry, police found that the Innova allegedly hit the tempo from behind, causing the three-wheeler to overturn on the flyover.

The occupants of the tempo were residents of Seelampur in northeast Delhi and were travelling to a temple in Gurugram when the accident took place, officials said.

The woman who died was

identified as Kripa Devi (47), who succumbed to her injuries at the spot, they said.

Five other occupants of the tempo sustained injuries and were shifted to the Safdarjung Hospital through CATS ambulances. They were identified as Vansh (8), Savitri Devi (60), Naina (34), Naksh (14) and Ishan (2). The condition of the injured was not immediately known.

Police said the tempo driver also sustained minor injuries in the accident.

According to the Delhi Fire Service (DFS), it received information about the accident at 4.35 am and dispatched a team to the location.

PROCLAMATION OF SALE

(Under Order 21, Rule 66)

IN THE COURT OF **Sh. Naresh Kumar Laka LD**, District Judge-07, Central District, Room No. 308, 3rd Floor, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054.
EX. NO.1947/2026
CS DJ.14949/2016

NDOH: 31.07.2026
ACJ : 27.05.2026

Pritpal Singh & Another
Versus
Hindpal Singh & Others

MEMO OF PARTIES
Sh. Hind Pal Singh S/o Late Sh. Partap Singh,
R/o V-272, 3rd Floor, Rajouri Garden, New Delhi
Also At:
J-3/199, Nehru Market, Rajouri Garden, New Delhi.

.... Applicant

Versus

1. Late Sh. Bhagwant Singh, (Since Deceased) Through his Legal Heirs,
a). Smt. Ramesh Kaur W/o Late Bhagwant Singh (Since Deceased),
b). Sh. Gobind Singh S/o Late Sh. Bhagwant Singh,
c). Sh. Hari Krishan Singh S/o Late Bhagwant Singh, All R/o G-62, Sant Nagar Extn., Near Lakkar Wala Pul, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi.
d). Smt. Parveen Kaur W/o Sh. Gurbachan Singh, R/o G-1, Sant Nagar Extn., Near Lakkar Wala Pul, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi.

2. Sh. Pritpal Singh S/o Late Sh. Partap Singh, R/o Pocket A-8, H. N. 140, 1st Floor, Kalkaji Extn., New Delhi.
3. Sh. Surinder Pal Singh S/o Late Sh. Partap Singh
4. Sh. Jasbir Singh S/o Late Sh. Partap Singh (Since Deceased), Through his Legal Heirs:
a). Smt. Parmjeet Kaur Widow of Late Jasbir Singh,
b). Ms. Anampreet D/o Late Jasbir Singh,
c). Ms. Harpreet Kaur D/o Late Jasbir Singh,
d). Master Javand Singh (Minor) S/o Late Jasbir Singh, Through St. Parmajeet Kaur,
5. Sh. Mandhir Singh S/o Late Sh. Partap Singh, All R/o J-3/199, Nehru Market, Rajouri Garden, New Delhi.

.... Judgment Debtor

To,

The Court Auctioneer, Sh. Tejeshwar Singh Bakshi, Adv.
(Enrollment No. D/933/2004), Chamber No. 291, Civil Side,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi-110054.

Notice is hereby given that, under Rule 64 of Order XXI of the Code of Civil Procedure, 1908, an order dated **14.05.2026** has been passed by this Court for the sale of the suit property mentioned in the annexed schedule, in satisfaction of the claim of the decree-holder in the execution arising out of under mentioned suit no. CS DJ. 14949/2016, Judgment and Final Decree dated **14.05.2018 & 25.05.2026**, the reserved price of the property is fixed at **Rs. 2.5 Crore** and earnest money is as per rule and shall be given on or before the date of auction by bidders.

(1)

The sale of suit property **J-3/199, Nehru Market, Rajouri Garden, New Delhi-110027** as mentioned in the schedule will be held by public auction on **24.07.2026 at 11:00 AM** and the liabilities and claims attaching to the said property, so far as they have been ascertained, are those specified in the schedule.

In the absence of any order of the postponement, the sale will be held by Court Auctioneer on **24.07.2026 at 11:00 AM** on the spot.

At the sale, the public generally are invited to bid, either personally or by duly authorized agent. No bid by, or on behalf of the Judgment-debtor above mentioned, however, will be accepted, nor will any sale to them be valid without the express permission of the Court previously given, The following are the further:-

Conditions of Sale

1. The particulars specified in the schedule below have been stated to the best of the information of the Court, but the Court will not be answerable for any error, mis-statement or omission in this proclamation.

2. The amount by which the biddings are to be increased shall be determined by the officer conducting the sale. In the event of any dispute arising as to the amount bid, or as to the bidder, the lot shall at once be again put up to auction.

3. The highest bidder shall be declared to be the purchaser of any lot, provided always that he is legally qualified to bid, and provided that it shall be in the discretion of the Court or officer holding the sale to decline acceptance of the highest bid when the price offered appears so clearly inadequate as to make it advisable to do so.

4. For reasons recorded, it shall be in the discretion of the officer conducting the sale to adjourn it subject always to the provisions of rule 69 of Order XXI.

5. In the case of movable property, the price of each lot shall be paid at the time of sale or as soon after as the officer holding the sale directs, and in default of payment the property shall forthwith be again put up and re-sold.

6. In the case of immovable property the person declared to be the purchaser shall pay immediately after such declaration a deposit of 25 per cent. On the amount of his purchase-money to the officer conducting the sale, and in default of such deposit the property shall forthwith be put up again and re-sold.

7. The full amount of the purchase-money shall be paid by the purchaser before the Court closed on the **Thirtieth (30th)** day after the sale of the property, exclusive of such day, of it the fifteenth day be a Sunday or other holiday, then in the first office day after the **Thirtieth (30th)** day.

8. In default of payment of the balance of purchase money within the period allowed, the property shall be re-sold after the issue of a fresh notification of sale, may, if the Court thinks fit, be forfeited to Government and the defaulting purchaser shall forfeit all claim to the property or to any part of the sum for which it may be subsequently sold.

9. This proclamation be read with additional condition as per order dated **14.05.2026 & 25.05.2026.**

Given under my hand and the seal of the Court, this **26.05.2026.**

SEAL

District Judge, Central-07,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

Schedule of Property

Number of lot:	Description of property to be sold with the name of each owner where there are more than one:	The revenue assessed upon the estate or part of the estate, if the property to be sold is an interest in an estate paying revenue to Government:	Detail of any encumbrance, if any, to which the property is liable:	Claims if any, which have been put forward to the property and any known particulars bearing on its nature and value:	Reserve Price:
	J-3/199, Nehru Market, Rajouri Garden, New Delhi-110027.	-----	-----	-----	Rs.2.5 Crore

Charges for Beat of Drum Rs.500/- has already been deposited vide receipt no. 78 Dated 19.05.2026

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Kartaro Bai, Mother of No.15587912F SPR Sukhwinder Singh, R/o-Vill- Reond Kalan, Dist-Mansa, Teh- Budhlada, Punjab- 151503, have changed my name from Kartaro Bai to Taro Bai, vide affidavit dated 06/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(1289)C

I, Prahlad Rai, Father of JC-857301K Sub(OPR) Chunni Ram, R/o- Vill- Hathyawal, PO- Kheruwala, Teh-Sadulshahar, Dist-Sriganganagar, Rajasthan-335062, have changed my name from Prahlad Rai to Prahlad Ram, vide affidavit dated 06/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(1291)C

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Eight people, including four children, two women, and two men, were rescued, and two pet dogs died of suffocation from a residential building in South Delhi's New Friends Colony on Sunday afternoon after a fire broke out on the first floor and thick smoke blocked the central staircase, trapping residents on upper floors. Fire officials explicitly dismissed reports circulating about a child dying in the incident. No human casualties were reported.

The Delhi Fire Service received a call at around 3:50 pm. Police Station New Friends Colony received a PCR call at around 3:45 pm. A senior police official immediately led a team to house

People react on site after a fire breaks out in a house in the New Friends Colony area in New Delhi

Request for Bid

Online bids are invited from the intending bidders for the following tender:

● **Tender Title;** Design, Supply and Commissioning of PUP Panel-based IOT Smart Toilets for Males, Females, PwD, and Diaper changing cabins at various locations in Assam

● The last date of submission of tender document is 30/06/2026 which has to be submitted through the Assam Tenders portal only

The detailed tender document may be downloaded from the Assam Tenders portal i.e <https://assamtenders.gov.in> from 08/06/2026. The bid reference number is: IOT/PHE/OOI.

Sd/-

Chief Engineer (PHE), Sanitation, Assam

DIPR/C/PIO/82/8-Jun-26

Betkuchi, Guwahati

THE SIRSA CENTRAL COOPERATIVE BANK LTD; H.O SIRSA

SHORT TERM RE-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Start Date & End Date	Opening of Technical & Financial Bid
1	Supply and Installation of 25 computer set Approx Amt. Rs. 2200000/- Earnest Money Deposit Rs. 25000/-	08-06-2026 at 10.00 AM To 23-06-2026 upto 5.00 PM	24-06-2026 At 11.00 AM

The Tender forms (non transferable) contains terms & conditions and specifications/job descriptions of the above mentioned work may be downloaded from website <https://etenders.hry.nic.in> and www.sirsadccb.bank.in

General Manager
CB Sirsa

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NOTICE

SAFE DEPOSIT LOCKER HOLDERS

The following persons, customers of our branches mentioned below,

Sr. No.	Name of customer	Branch	Locker no.	Locker rent pending since	Locker not operated since
1.	Shobha Grover / Vijay Dawra	Faridabad	B0012	02-03-2022	27-09-2018

are hereby notified that despite issuance of individual notices for long outstanding rent for 3 years and above/ Inoperative for more than 7 years and followed by issuance of a final notice to effect break open of the locker(s), you have failed to respond to the Bank's notice for operating/ surrendering the locker/ paying arrears of rent due within the 3 months specified therein. It is also observed in some of the cases that the notices/ letters sent by the Bank have remained undelivered and eventually returned and the locker hirers are not traceable. In accordance to the terms and conditions for hiring of the locker duly accepted by the locker hirers by executing the 'Memorandum for hiring locker', the Bank may break open/ take repossession by breaking open the lockers of such hirers to check the contents kept therein for security reasons/ realize its dues, charges and expenses by public or private sales of the part or whole of the contents of the locker and hold the balance of the contents or proceeds of sale, entirely at the risk and responsibility of the hirer as to the cost and consequences thereof, pursuant to the powers vested in the Bank under the arrangement for hiring of lockers, should the Bank not receive the outstanding rent for 3 years and above with penalty applicable / Locker to be operated within 3 months from the date of publication of this notice.

Please contact your concerned branch for queries if any .

Sd/-

SVC Co-op. Bank Ltd.

Address:- 1A/260, Neelam Bata Road, NIT, Faridabad, Haryana- 121001

Date: 08/06/2026
Place: Faridabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Rain lashes parts of Capital

Delhi experienced a sudden change in weather, with rain lashing parts of the national capital on Sunday, bringing much-needed relief from the prevailing heat conditions. Visuals from near Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport showed rain lashing several areas around the airport.

The showers led to a noticeable drop in temperature, offering respite to residents who had been enduring hot and humid conditions over the past few days. Delhi recorded the maximum temperature of 41.6 degrees Celsius on Sunday, 1.6 notches above the seasonal average. The national capital is expected to witness hot weather over the next seven days, with maximum temperatures ranging from 36 degrees Celsius to 41 degrees Celsius and minimum temperatures between 26 degrees Celsius and 29 degrees Celsius.

Independent weather forecaster Navdeep Dahiya has flagged a sharp rise in daytime temperatures across Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, Delhi-NCR and Uttar Pradesh, with maximums touching 42 to 46 degrees Celsius. The peak is likely around June 10 and 11, before some relief arrives by Friday. The main culprit is a steady stream of hot, dry winds blowing in from the north-west. Scientists call this advection, which simply means heat being carried from one place to another by the wind.

On June 7, temperatures are likely to range between 28 degrees Celsius and 40 degrees Celsius, with partly cloudy skies and a possibility of thunderstorms accompanied by lightning. The weather is expected to remain mostly clear on June 8, when the mercury may hover between 28 degrees Celsius and 41 degrees Celsius. Similar temperatures are forecast for June 9, with daytime conditions likely to be accompanied by strong surface winds. On June 10, the minimum temperature

may rise to 29 degrees Celsius while the maximum could touch 41 degrees Celsius, with gusty winds continuing during the day.

A change in weather is expected on June 11, when temperatures may vary between 29 degrees Celsius and 40 degrees Celsius, along with the likelihood of thunderstorms and rainfall. The wet spell is expected to continue on June 12, with temperatures dropping to between 26degrees Celsius and 36 degrees Celsius, as rain and thunderstorms are likely to provide some respite from the prevailing heat.

Earlier on Saturday, the IMD forecast that the maximum temperature is likely to remain around 40 degrees Celsius on Sunday and may rise to 42 degrees Celsius by Tuesday.

The minimum temperature settled at 27.7 degrees Celsius, 0.1 notches above the seasonal average.

The weather department has predicted mainly clear skies on Monday, with the maximum and minimum temperatures expected to reach around 42 and 28 degrees Celsius, respectively. Relative humidity was recorded at 31 per cent at 5.30 pm.



सत्यमेव जयते

दिल्ली सरकार

12 साल विश्वास के, विकास के, जनकल्याण के



आदरणीय प्रधानमंत्री
श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी जी को

समस्त दिल्लीवासियों की ओर से
हार्दिक बधाई एवं शुभकामनाएं



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

Delhi hotel fire: Death toll rises to 22 as Nigerian national dies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The death toll in the Malviya Nagar hotel fire has climbed to 22 after another foreign national, a Nigerian citizen, succumbed to injuries during treatment, Delhi Police confirmed on Sunday. Out of the 22 dead, 13 are foreign nationals, and nine are Indian citizens, making the June 3 blaze at Flourish Stay in Hauz Rani the deadliest hotel fire in Delhi in recent memory.

The Ministry of External Affairs had earlier confirmed that among the foreign nationals killed were four from Nigeria, three from Kyrgyzstan, and one each from Mozambique, Liberia, Uzbekistan, Bangladesh, Congo, and Iraq. The latest



death, a Nigerian national, adds to the Nigerian toll from the fire and brings the overall count to 22.

The MEA also confirmed that around 22 foreign nationals had been injured in the incident, with Indian authorities in touch with the concerned embassies and facilitating necessary assistance, including documentation and medical support.

The fire broke out on the morning of June 3 at Flourish Stay, a bed-and-breakfast facility in the narrow lanes of Hauz Rani, a congested locality in south Delhi's Malviya Nagar. The Delhi Fire Service received information about the blaze at around 9 am. More than 40 people were rescued and rushed to the hospital, where 21 were initially declared dead. Several

occupants, with no route of escape through the building's single staircase, which was choked with smoke, jumped from upper floors as locals spread mattresses on the road below in a desperate attempt to break their fall.

The building had been operating in a web of violations. Licensed for only six rooms under Delhi's bed-and-breakfast scheme, it was allegedly running 25 rooms, including accommodation in the basement. It had no valid fire safety clearance, only one entry and exit point, and sealed windows. Additional floors had been built over the years without informing authorities or obtaining any structural or fire safety approval.

Parvesh Singh calls for citizen-centric governance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Water and Public Works Department Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Sunday directed Zonal Revenue Officers to strengthen public outreach, maintain transparency, and ensure government services reach every household across the capital. Chairing a review meeting at Varunalaya, the minister told officers that governance could succeed only when citizens directly experience the benefits of government schemes and welfare programmes in their daily lives.

The meeting focused on improving field-level administration, strengthening coordination among departments, and making governance more responsive to public needs. Addressing Zonal Revenue Officers, Singh said government officials must maintain regular contact with residents and actively engage with local communities instead of limiting their work to offices.

He instructed officers to visit local areas frequently, understand public



concerns, and ensure that eligible citizens are not deprived of government services because of a lack of information or administrative delays. "The real test of governance lies in what people experience in their everyday lives," the minister said during the meeting. He added that every citizen should be aware of the facilities and services being provided by the government and should know how to access them without unnecessary difficulties.

The minister stressed that officers should work with honesty, accountability, and complete transparency while carrying out their responsibilities. According to officials present at the

meeting, Singh emphasised that public trust in government institutions depends on responsive administration and regular interaction between citizens and officials. He said officers should act as a direct link between the administration and the public so that grievances are addressed quickly and effectively.

The minister also highlighted the importance of improving communication between departments and strengthening field-level governance mechanisms to ensure better service delivery across Delhi. Officials said the review meeting covered issues related to public outreach, grievance redressal systems, and monitoring of government schemes at the local level.

Singh directed officers to adopt a more proactive approach in resolving public complaints and ensuring that welfare initiatives reach intended beneficiaries on time. He also asked officers to maintain sensitivity while dealing with citizens and ensure that administrative procedures remain simple and accessible.

Delhi to hold mega Yamuna riverfront cleanliness campaign on June 14

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government will organise a large-scale Yamuna Riverfront Cleanliness Campaign on June 14 under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, with simultaneous clean-up and awareness programmes planned at several ghats across the capital.

The campaign aims to improve cleanliness along the Yamuna riverfront, increase public awareness about environmental protection, and encourage greater citizen participation in efforts to restore the river. The Chief Minister will personally participate in the programme and join volunteers and citizens during the drive.

According to the Chief Minister's Office, nearly 500 social, religious, educational, and voluntary organisations are expected to take part in the campaign along with thousands of volunteers from different parts of Delhi. Officials said cleanliness drives and awareness activities will be conducted simultaneously at major Yamuna ghats as part of the initiative.

The Delhi Government described the campaign as a major effort to strengthen public participation in environmental conservation and river cleaning activities. The Chief Minister said the Yamuna is deeply linked to Delhi's cultural, religious, and environmental identity, and that protecting the river is a collective responsibility. She said the responsibility for maintaining the Yamuna does not rest solely with government agencies and requires active cooperation from citizens as well.

The government has appealed to residents, social groups, youth organisations, and volunteers to participate actively in the programme. Officials said several departments and agencies have been directed to coordinate preparations for the campaign.

The local administration, Delhi Police, Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Health Department, and other concerned departments are making arrangements related to sanitation, security, traffic management, drinking water, and emergency services. Medical support and first-aid facilities will also be available at different locations during the event. The government said all arrangements are being made to ensure smooth participation by citizens and volunteers at multiple riverfront locations.



Officials said the June 14 campaign is being planned on a much larger scale compared to previous river-cleaning initiatives. The Chief Minister referred to the "Meri Yamuna, Mera Kartavya" campaign organised last year, which also focused on cleaning the Yamuna ghats and spreading awareness about river conservation.

According to the government, thousands of volunteers participated in that campaign, and more than 12 tonnes of waste were collected and scientifically disposed of. Officials said the response to the earlier initiative encouraged the government to expand the scale of this year's campaign.

BJP launches Karawal Nagar sewer project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra on Sunday announced a ₹138-crore sewer infrastructure project for Karawal Nagar, promising major improvements in drainage, drinking water



supply, and civic facilities in several parts of North-East Delhi.

The announcement was made during a public programme organised by the Delhi BJP in Karawal Nagar to mark 12 years of the Narendra Modi-led Central Government. Local MLA and Delhi Minister Kapil Mishra was present along

with MP Manoj Tiwari, Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, MLA Ajay Mahawar, and BJP district president Dr UK Chaudhary.

Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister said the sewer project would cover Sonia Vihar, Milan Garden, Chauhan Patti, Sabhapur Extension, and nearby colonies.

Govt defends LPG price hike

"Commercial gas carries a higher rate of tax and larger margins, so it sits above the household's cost-reflective level; even so, the import-linked cost of a domestic cylinder works out to over ₹1,600," the Government said in a statement.

The Government also argued that beneficiaries of the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana (PMUY) will continue to pay an effective ₹642 per cylinder after receiving a subsidy of ₹300 per refill on the first four refills annually, down from nine refills announced last year.

The Government released a comparison of LPG prices across countries comparing global prices to cylinders distributed under PMUY. According to the figures, an effective PMUY cylinder price of ₹642 is lower than Pakistan's ₹1,046, Nepal's ₹1,207, Bangladesh's approximately ₹1,225 and Sri Lanka's ₹1,241. The gap is wider when compared with developed countries. Equivalent prices were estimated at around ₹1,755 in the US, ₹1,765 in Australia and ₹2,411 in Canada.

The Government added that even a non-PMUY consumer paying ₹942 continues to pay about ₹700 less than the market-linked cost. Any household can buy as many cylinders as it needs at ₹942.

India's LPG import prices are linked to the Saudi Contract Price (CP), the global benchmark set by Saudi Aramco. According to the Government, the benchmark has risen by around 46 per cent since February. "India used to import 60 per cent of its LPG requirements, and the landed cost of that import tracks the Saudi Contract Price (CP) that Saudi Aramco sets at the start of each month. This is an external price over which the Indian consumer has no control," the Government said.

Nepal reaffirm bilateral route to resolve India...

The Nepalese PM had recently suggested that China and the United Kingdom could play a role in addressing the decades-old boundary dispute between Nepal and India.

India had earlier categorically rejected any role for third parties in resolving the border issue.

Clarifying Nepal's position, Khanal said Kathmandu was not seeking international mediation. Instead, references to the United Kingdom were related solely to obtaining historical documents and archival records that may help inform discussions.

"We want to solve our disputes through diplomatic processes. We just want to see if we can access some of the documents that might be in libraries or museums in the UK. Our position was not that we were asking for mediation," he explained.

The boundary dispute centres on the Lipulekh, Limpiyadhura, and Kalapani regions. Nepal claims the territories belong to it, while India maintains they are part of the northern state of Uttarakhand.

Addressing concerns over the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra route through Lipulekh, Khanal reiterated Nepal's objection to agreements between India and China concerning the area without Nepal's participation.

"Our concerns are with the renewal of the agreement between India and China over the Kalapani and Lipulekh area, where we have said for a very long time that the land belongs to us," he said. According to Khanal, Nepal has formally conveyed its position to both countries

through diplomatic channels and official notes. Despite these differences, he maintained that Kathmandu remains committed to resolving the issue through established bilateral frameworks rather than public confrontation.

Khanal described 2026 as a uniquely favorable moment for India and Nepal to elevate their relationship. "The year 2026 has provided the most conducive and highly aligned window for the two countries in decades to completely elevate and transform our relations," he said.

He emphasized the need to convert diplomatic commitments into tangible outcomes that improve the lives of citizens on both sides of the border. "Our primary responsibility is to close the gap between bold promises made on paper and the physical reality delivered on the ground," he remarked. Reflecting on the deep cultural and historical ties between the two nations, Khanal said India and Nepal share far more than a geographical boundary.

"We are not merely neighbours joined by political lines drawn on a map; we are the children of the same rivers, the same mountains and the same ancient wisdom," he said.

The minister also indicated that Nepal's new Government is eager to deepen engagement with India across trade, connectivity, energy, and technology sectors. When asked about domestic political developments in Nepal and recent protests, Khanal declined detailed comment, saying only that the politica

National Award winner Salim Kumar dies at 56

"Deeply saddened by the passing of veteran actor Shri Salim Kumar Ji. Over the course of a distinguished career, he made a mark with his versatility and memorable performances across a wide range of roles. My thoughts are with his family and countless admirers in this hour of grief. Om Shanti," Modi wrote on X.

Chief Minister VD Satheesan shared his deep sorrow over Kumar's death, calling him "more than a film star" and "a brother and family member." In his message, he said Salim Kumar was the pride of North Paravur.

Salim Kumar was the pride of North Paravur. The CM said in his condolence message that Salim Kumar was the pride of North Paravur. Kumar was born into a modest family that faced poverty and hardship, but he rose to the top of Indian cinema by winning the National Award. He was a rare talent whose work even reached the Oscar nomination stage. His public appearance was at a reception organised by the people of Paravur a few days ago.

Kumar was known for his versatility, moving from comedy to serious roles over a career of almost thirty years. He is survived by his wife, Sunitha, and their two children.

Bulldozers move into Sainik Farms

In South Delhi, 41 operations have taken place in areas like Said-ul-Ajaib, Hauz Rani, Khirki Extension, Savitri Nagar, Khanpur, Sainik Farms, and Gautam Nagar. Officials said violations in Sainik Farms included illegal additions, basements converted into guesthouses and B&Bs, and extensions built without approval.

The colony was first intended for defence personnel, but has become an area of farmhouses and luxury villas. Many of these buildings have

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ignored fire safety rules, a recurring concern after several incidents.

"The government is taking strong action against unauthorised construction, encroachments, and violations of fire safety norms," the chief minister said and emphasised the need for a long-term solution to stop illegal activity. Her office described the Sainik Farms operation as a clear message that all neighbourhoods, regardless of status, will be treated equally.

The crackdown is politically important. Sainik Farms has a long history of illegal construction, and previous High Court orders have had little effect. During the previous AAP government, enforcement was often seen as selective. Gupta's administration is showing zero tolerance, which is a change from the past. Videos on social media of bulldozers at work have gained support from law-abiding citizens but have worried property owners. Many residents, who are wealthy and well-connected, now face a different situation. "This is not politics; this is governance," a senior MCD official said anonymously. "Court orders, safety norms and public interest cannot be ignored anymore."

In addition to demolitions, new surveys are being conducted to identify further violations, and warnings are being issued regarding action against the use of residential plots for business purposes. The government says this campaign is part of a bigger plan to improve the city.

As bulldozers prepare for the next phase, the CM's office makes it clear that ignoring violations is no longer an option. For a city that has faced preventable disasters, today's action in Sainik Farms could be the beginning of real accountability. People in Delhi are watching to see if this effort continues.

Property dispute ends in murder of DU professor

Devarati reached the apartment, found the door locked from the outside, broke it open, and discovered the body inside. There were no signs of forced entry or theft, which led investigators to conclude from the outset that the killers were known to the victim.

The arrested accused are Ramprashad Das, 42; his wife, Banashree Das, 36; and their minor son. According to police, the Das family had been residing in a property belonging to Paul in Bardhaman since 2023. The property had come to Paul through a family settlement. She had asked them to vacate repeatedly over the years. The dispute had continued without resolution until recently, when she issued a final warning to vacate. Investigators say this final warning triggered the decision to kill her.

The three travelled to Delhi on June 3 with a premeditated plan. To avoid being traced through their real identities, they checked into a guest house in Dallupura using Aadhaar credentials that did not belong to them. Police later identified the fake identities through guest house records and placed the mobile numbers associated with those credentials under surveillance, which proved crucial in tracking the family's movements.

They visited Paul's flat and murdered her after she refused once more to back down on the property. After killing her, they locked the apartment from the outside and left. They then made their way out of the building using both staircases and lifts, keeping their faces concealed. Investigators who later reviewed extensive CCTV footage from the housing complex and sur-

rounding areas were able to track their movements step by step.

After leaving the building, the family took a taxi and an autorickshaw to reach Anand Vihar. From there, they proceeded to New Delhi Railway Station and boarded the Poorva Express at around 5:40 pm on June 3. They reached Bardhaman the following day.

Police examined CCTV footage from Bardhaman railway station to narrow down their location. A police team flew to West Bengal on June 6 and continued the ground search. On Sunday, June 7, the trio was located at their hideout and arrested.

From the accused, police recovered Paul's Samsung mobile phone, a razor allegedly used in the crime, clothing, a cap, a backpack, and train tickets. A case under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which covers murder, has been registered. Further investigation is underway.

The case is methodical in its planning and brutal in its execution. A family that had been living rent-free in a disputed property for over two years, facing eviction after the owner's final warning, travelled the length of a country with a child in tow, used someone else's identity to book a room, killed the woman who owned the house, and caught the evening train home.

Indian shot dead in US

Upon arrival, an unidentified assailant allegedly opened fire, shooting him multiple times in the head before fleeing the scene.

His sister, Tanvi Kuncha, alleged that the delivery request was a deliberate setup intended to lure and kill him. "He was told to deliver pizza in an abandoned area, but we later learned it was a decoy. There was no one there; it was a trap meant solely to kill him. We do not know what they gained or what their intentions were. They took my brother and killed him," she said.

Appealing for the swift repatriation of her brother's body, Tanvi said officials informed the family that the body could be released on Monday and urged authorities to expedite the process to allow the family to perform his final rites without delay.

She also called for justice, saying the family has no specific suspicions regarding those responsible but wants the perpetrators identified and punished. In an emotional appeal, Tanvi urged parents to carefully consider sending their children abroad. "This is a message to all parents considering sending their children to the US. My brother was a very loving and joyful person. He had no real reason to go to the US, but we sent him anyway. He didn't want to go either, and look where it got him. Do not send your children to the US," she said.

Shah orders vigil on land deals on border

Shah said that keeping the borders secure is a shared job for district officials, revenue officers, village leaders, and local communities.

These actions aim to spot and stop activities that could help cross-border crime, illegal immigration, or allow anti-national groups to use real estate or financial deals as cover.

Financial transactions, property sales and purchases, and big construction projects along the borders will now be watched more closely.

States are responsible for ensuring financial discipline in these districts. The Central Board of Direct

Taxes (CBDT) will also check for fake currency in border areas. Shah also asked for close monitoring of population changes in border districts and the creation of security coordination groups that include the BSF, Income Tax, and the Enforcement Directorate.

Special training camps will also be set up for people living near the border to help them deal with drug and gun threats. These camps will include revenue officials, local police, and BSF staff.

Home minister Shah further announced upgrading BSF cameras along the border and connecting them directly to district control rooms. Tripura will be the first state to use this system, which will later be used in other India-Bangladesh border states.

This order is part of Shah's ongoing tour to review border security in several states. In recent weeks, he has led similar meetings in Rajasthan and Gujarat along the India-Pakistan border. There, he ordered that all illegal buildings within 15 km of the border be demolished as part of a strict zero-tolerance policy.

The dabbawalas who once fed Mumbai now...

"A *dabbawalas* typically serves 15 to 20 customers and charges a monthly fee for delivery of lunchbox from home to offices. The network functions through station-wise groups that coordinate collection and delivery operations. However, there is no formal registration system for workers," he said. According to the association, *dabbawalas* currently deliver more than 50,000 lunchboxes daily to offices.

dabbawalas Subhash Talekar also cited the rise of food-delivery platforms and cloud kitchens for the dent in the network's business, adding that the younger generation are opting for such mechanisms than waiting for delivery of home-cooked meals. The association's office bearer Raghunath Mendge said the service was at its peak towards the end of the last century when the network had more than 5,000 *dabbawalas* before changing lifestyles and the easy availability of food began showing their effects.

In the late 1990s and early 2000s, *dabbawalas* largely collected tiffins from the suburbs and extended suburbs such as Vasai-Virar, Kalyan-Badlapur and the Belapur-Panvel belt for delivery to offices in south Mumbai, he pointed out.

The delivery process begins with *dabbawalas* collecting lunchboxes, each marked with an alphanumeric code for accurate sorting, from customers' homes, mostly using bicycles, although some now use e-bikes and scooters, he said. Mendge, whose father joined the profession in 1930, said when he entered the service in 1974, the monthly charge for delivering a lunchbox was just ₹12. Today, the monthly fee ranges from ₹1,500 to ₹2,500, he added.

An individual *dabbawala* earns around ₹15,000 to ₹25,000 a month, depending on the volume of work undertaken, he said.

"Many customers still approach *dabbawalas* directly after noticing their distinctive attire, particularly the Gandhi cap. Nowadays, some customers also contact us through phone numbers available online or through security personnel in their housing societies," he said.

The service, which started in 1890, will not stop, Mendge said confidently. The association said efforts were underway to attract new customers and adapt to changing work patterns to sustain the century-old service.

GRAPEVINE

Venezuela's Sai Baba link

It is always wonder to observe the devotion of Sai Baba by Communist leaders of Venezuela. When in 2005, President Hugo Chavez visited Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) with fanfare, entire delegation landed with him in India, spent time at Sai Baba Ashram in Puttaparti, Andhra Pradesh. The US caught Nicolas Maduro, who later became President and current interim President Delcy Rodriguez spend days in Sai Ashram, while supreme Chavez was energising JNU campus in Delhi. This time also Delcy found time to land in Sai Baba Ashram. Indian Communists fail to explain this sort of ideological differences and passion of Venezuelan communists to Sai Baba Ashram.

Have your cake and eat it too!

Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha's deft handling of the CJP protest earned plaudits by turning a potential flashpoint into a well-orchestrated event. As Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke landed from the United States on June 6, officers greeted him at IGI Airport, swiftly secured his signature on an undertaking, and, within minutes, granted permission for a one-time protest at Jantar Mantar through an expedited process. Instead of risking defiance and unrest by imposing a ban amid outrage over NEET leaks and exam scams, authorities channelled Gen-Z protestors into a sanctioned 10 am to 5 pm window, keeping tensions in check. Over 1,000 personnel kept VIP zones secure, and the protest unfolded peacefully as hundreds gathered.

Your Left is my Right

The suspension of two senior IAS B Ashok (1998) and N Prasanth (2007) has been revoked by the Congress-led UDF Government in Kerala. Both were suspended by the previous LDF administration. Prasanth had been placed under suspension in 2024 over allegations of misconduct arising from his public remarks and social media posts while Ashok was suspended after disciplinary proceedings were initiated against him over alleged violations of service conduct norms, including critical remarks made about the Government in the public domain. The orders, however, clarified that the disciplinary proceedings initiated against the officers would continue independently in accordance with the applicable service rules.

Mann knows little beyond cracking jokes, says Haryana CM in Punjab

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dhuri (Punjab)

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said his Punjab counterpart knows little beyond cracking jokes and not enough to run a Government. "Jokes can run cinema halls, but they cannot run governments," Saini said about Bhagwant Mann, a former standup comedian.



Meanwhile, Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillon, promised all-round development of the state if his party is voted to power, and claimed that Mann will not contest from Dhuri constituency in the 2027 Assembly polls. Addressing a public gathering here, Saini said that the enthusiasm of the people of Dhuri indicates a strong wave of change in the State. The BJP leader alleged that the AAP leaders portrayed themselves as revolutionaries, but in reality, they misled the public. Dhuri is Mann's constituency, yet he has distanced himself not only from Punjab but also from Dhuri, he said.

"Punjab was once far ahead of many States in terms of development, but political parties pursuing their own interests have pushed it into the category of laggards. Today, the war against drugs in Punjab is being fought only through newspaper ads, while little is being done on the ground," Saini said. He said Punjab's farmers are the nation's food providers and they trusted the Aam Aadmi Party in 2022, but got neither the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for all their crops, nor compensated for crop losses.

Opposition INDIA Bloc to meet

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As many as 23 political parties of the Opposition INDIA bloc will meet on Monday to redraw their strategy to take on the BJP and iron out differences amid changed power dynamics after the defeat of regional anchors TMC and DMK in the recent Assembly polls.

Top leaders of Opposition parties including Congress' Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge, TMC's Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek Banerjee, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, Tejashwi Yadav of RJD and Uddhav Thackeray of Shiv Sena (UBT), besides Left leaders and those from smaller parties, are likely to attend the meeting at the Constitution Club in the national Capital.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said that 23 political parties have confirmed their participation in the "INDIA janbandhan" meeting, while asserting that



the Opposition bloc continues to stand united through its diversity.

Ramesh claimed some parties have expressed their inability to attend this meeting for their own reasons even though they have conveyed their strong Opposition to the Modi Government's policies and actions. While the DMK and AAP are unlikely to attend, TVK is likely to be

included in the bloc. AAP has already publicly distanced itself from the bloc, while the DMK earlier announced its decision to boycott the gathering after the Congress snapped ties with it in Tamil Nadu and joined the TVK-led Government.

The alliance is set to deliberate on the future course of action and will aim to put a united face to take on the Modi

Government on national issues in the run-up to the next election cycle in States and the 2029 Lok Sabha elections.

The recent defeat of Trinamool Congress (TMC) in West Bengal has also forced the Opposition bloc to come together to take on the saffron surge in the country. The TMC is likely to raise the issue of alleged attacks on its leaders in Bengal and rally support of INDIA bloc parties.

The recent Assembly elections have, however, also brought out differences within the opposition bloc, with the CPI-M set to raise with the Congress the charge that the Left had a political understanding with the BJP in Kerala polls. The Left parties lost against the Congress-led UDF in the only State they were in power.

The INDIA alliance, formed ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, comprises several Opposition parties that have sought to jointly challenge the BJP-led NDA at the national level.

Mamata travels to Delhi to attend INDIA bloc meet

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee travelled to Delhi on Sunday, a day ahead of the INDIA bloc meeting, amid speculation of a possible split among the party's MPs in Parliament. The former West Bengal chief minister was accompanied by Rajya Sabha MP Dola Sen and veteran Lok Sabha MP Kalyan Banerjee.

TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee travelled to the national capital on Saturday as the party leadership grappled with growing indications that the rebellion, which cost it control of its legislature wing in the West Bengal Assembly, could spread to its parliamentary party.

Mamata Banerjee and her nephew Abhishek were earlier scheduled to travel to Delhi together on Sunday for the Opposition INDIA bloc's meeting, but the Diamond Harbour MP went a



TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee interacting with AAP National Convenor Arvind Kejriwal in New Delhi on Sunday

day ahead. The top TMC leadership is expected to make a first-hand assessment of the situation within its own house before Monday's INDIA bloc meeting amid reports of moves by dissident TMC leaders and MPs to replicate in Parliament what already happened in the Assembly.

In one of the biggest setbacks for Mamata Banerjee since the party's formation in 1998, more than two-thirds of TMC MLAs — 58 of the 80 legislators

— broke away from its official legislature wing last week and secured recognition as the principal opposition bloc under expelled MLA Ritabrata Banerjee.

Sources familiar with the developments claimed efforts were underway to mobilise support among MPs in both Houses of Parliament.

Hectic parleys are expected during Mamata Banerjee's stay in Delhi to keep her flock together, given indications that the rebel party MPs may make their move within a few days.

According to rebel TMC MLA and deputy leader of the party's new legislative wing, Sandipan Saha, a development similar to that in the West Bengal Assembly is taking place within the parliamentary party in New Delhi.

Several TMC leaders have openly spoken up against Abhishek Banerjee and his leadership way following the Mamata Banerjee-led party's debacle in last month's Assembly elections.

India, Indonesia explore deeper ties in defence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar hosted his Indonesian counterpart Sugiono for wide-ranging talks on Sunday, exploring ways to deepen cooperation in areas of defence, maritime trade, investments, pharmaceuticals, semiconductors, and food security.

Indonesia is an important partner of India in the Southeast Asian region and the overall ties including in trade and investment between the two sides have been on an upswing in the last few years. Sugiono is currently on a three-day visit to New Delhi.

In a post on 'X', Jaishankar said the India-Indonesia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership has witnessed a strong growth in recent years. "Held substantive discussions on our political, defence and security, maritime & shipping, trade, fintech, health, pharmaceuticals, fertiliser, critical mineral as well as tourism, education and cultural cooperation."

"Also exchanged perspectives on regional developments, advancing our multi-



Union External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and Indonesian Foreign Minister Sugiono during the 8th India-Indonesia Joint Commission Meeting on Sunday

lateral coordination and deepening India-ASEAN ties," he said. The two ministers are also learnt to have deliberated on the economic fallout of the West Asia crisis.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said Jaishankar and Sugiono reviewed the full spectrum of bilateral relations under the India-Indonesia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.

"They discussed avenues for further strengthening cooperation in political, defence and security, mar-

itime, trade and investment, pharma and healthcare,

digital, energy, connectivity, space, education, consular and culture domains, and people-to-people exchanges," it said. Jaishankar and Sugiono also welcomed the "upward and growing" trajectory of bilateral relations.

"It's a great pleasure to welcome you and your delegation to New Delhi for the eighth India-Indonesia Joint Commission meeting," Jaishankar said in his opening remarks at the meeting. The external affairs minister also recalled the "fruitful" talks between Prime Minister Narendra

Modi and Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto during his visit to India in January last year. The visit has certainly imparted fresh momentum to our comprehensive strategic partnership, he said.

"Indonesia is a key pillar of India's Act East Policy. Rooted in deep civilisational linkages, the India-Indonesia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership continues to grow from strength to strength across established and new areas of cooperation," the MEA said in a statement.

India's space economy can expand to \$45 billion over next 7-8 years: Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's space economy, currently close to \$9 billion, is expected to expand to about \$45 billion over the next seven to eight years, Union Minister Jitendra Singh said on Sunday.

The minister also stated that India's space startup ecosystem has grown from a single-digit number of startups a few years ago to around 400 today.

"The Prime Minister Narendra Modi Government has opened strategic sectors such as space and parts of the nuclear ecosystem to private participation, ending decades of restricted access," Singh said. He made these com-



ments while reflecting on the last 12 years of the Modi Government during an interaction with the media. "The change of mindset that has happened in the last 12 years under Prime

Minister Modi is one of the biggest hallmarks. The kind of aspirational surge that has happened, I can also do it, was not there earlier," the minister said.

He added that this shift was visible in the growing number of civil services toppers emerging from small towns and non-metropolitan backgrounds, reflecting the democratisation of opportunity through technology, transparency and fair competition.

Singh also noted that India's successful landing near the Moon's south pole had strengthened public interest in science, while earlier discoveries by Indian lunar missions had helped identify evidence of water molecules on the Moon.

NFHS-6 indicators not omitted: Health Ministry

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Health Ministry sources said the indicators claimed to have been "omitted" in the National Family Health Survey (NFHS)-6 Fact Sheets are being monitored through dedicated national surveys and administrative databases, and therefore were not duplicated in the preliminary release.

This comes after criticism by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, who questioned the exclusion of certain key health and nutrition indicators from the recently released NFHS-6 Fact Sheets and alleged that the data reflected shortcomings in the Government's healthcare and nutrition policies.



Senior officials in the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare said the fact sheets represent only the first stage of dissemination and cover 101 major indicators intended to provide a concise snapshot of India's most critical health and demographic trends.

"The fact sheets are the first stage of dissemination. The

Gujarat deploys senior IPS officers for border security

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Gandhinagar/New Delhi

Eight senior IPS officers will conduct a two-day field review in 16 border villages of Gujarat on June 11 and 12, according to officials. The exercise, led by Deputy Chief Minister and Home Minister Harsh Sanghavi, is intended to provide a direct assessment of security and administrative conditions, moving beyond routine inspections.

These officers will stay in local homes, interact with residents, and hold meetings to identify security and

Udhamo and Patagar, ACP R T Susra will cover Purajpur and Gunau, and DIG Sudha Pandey will stay in Dinara and Bhitara-Mota.

During the visit, officers will inspect border outposts, monitor night patrols, review the functioning of police stations, and consult with villagers regarding security and essential services. The state Government has termed this an intensive border-security and rural-review exercise, highlighting its operational focus.

It may be recalled that a similar initiative was con-



governance challenges. The selected villages are located in Vav-Tharad, Patan, and Kutch districts, which are considered sensitive due to frequent reports of infiltration and smuggling.

The team comprises Additional Director Generals, Inspectors General, Deputy Inspectors General, and one Assistant Commissioner of Police. ADGP Wabang Jamir will visit Sargam and Rachhena in Vav-Tharad. ADGP Ajay Kumar Chaudhary will go to Shiranivandh and Jatawada in Kutch (East), and IG Bipin Ahire will visit Dhokawada and Charanka in Patan. In Vav-Tharad, DIG A M Muniya will inspect Radosan and Golap. In Kutch (West), DIG K N Damor will assess Juna and Dedhiya, DIG Leena Patil will review

ducted in November last year, when Sanghavi led a team of senior IPS officers to border villages in Kutch and Banaskantha to assess infrastructure and living conditions. That review resulted in accelerated development projects and improved coordination among the police, the BSF, and the district administration.

The two-day stay of senior IPS officers in border villages is intended to strengthen security preparedness and reinforce the state government's commitment to residents in these areas, some of which are located only a few metres from the international border. Findings from this exercise will inform the home department's border management strategy for the coming year, officials said.

Digvijaya urges PM Modi to pause three-language policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior Congress leader Digvijaya Singh has written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, flagging concerns over the mandatory implementation of the three-language policy for Class IX students by the CBSE in the current mid-session, and urging him to put it on hold.

Singh, who is also the chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, said the sudden enforcement of this policy mid-session without adequate teachers, textbooks, or transition time, is likely to create serious disruption, "not unlike the chaos witnessed during the hasty implementation of CBSE's On-Screen Marking (OSM) system."

"I am forwarding herewith a representation received from a group of concerned parents of CBSE Class IX students, opposing the mandatory implementation of the three-language policy in the current mid-



session," Singh said in his letter to Modi.

"Having gone through the representation, I find the concerns raised to be genuine and deserving of immediate attention. The sudden enforcement of this policy mid-session — without adequate teachers, textbooks, or transition time is likely to create serious disruption, not unlike the chaos witnessed during the hasty implementation of CBSE's On-Screen Marking (OSM) system, which adversely impacted lakhs of students across the country," the Congress leader said.

Further, Singh said, it has been brought to his attention that the CBSE's govern-

ing body in its meeting in December 2025 had ratified the Curriculum Committee's recommendation that 'schools continue with the existing Scheme of Studies especially with regards to language until the release of graded textbooks of languages by NCERT'.

Despite its own Governing Body's decision, the CBSE issued a circular on May 15, 2026, asking for the implementation of third language instruction in Grade IX from 1st July 2026, the RS MP said.

The NCERT has not yet released graded textbooks of language and the CBSE has, therefore, recommended the use of the NCERT's Grade 6 textbooks, he said.

coherence across India's expanding statistical ecosystem. "The objective is to ensure that each indicator is reported through the most appropriate and authoritative source, reducing duplication and improving overall data coherence," an official source said.

Officials noted that several indicators cited as missing from the fact sheets are already being monitored through dedicated national systems. Sanitation and clean cooking fuel coverage, for instance, are tracked through specialised surveys and administrative platforms such as Swachh Survekshan Grameen and surveys conducted by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, making duplication within the fact sheets unnecessary they said.

■ States Focus ■



PRESIDENT, PM HAIL INDIA'S SAFF WOMEN'S FOOTBALL WIN

President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday congratulated the Indian women's football team on winning the SAFF championship. India clinched the SAFF (South Asian Football Federation) Women's Championships football title for the sixth time and first after seven years with a dominant 3-1 win over Bangladesh in the summit clash in Goa on Saturday. "Heartiest congratulations to the Indian Women's Football Team on winning the SAFF Women's Championship 2026! Our women footballers displayed exceptional skill, determination and teamwork throughout the tournament," Murmu said in a post on social media. "I am confident that their remarkable achievement will inspire young girls across the nation to pursue their dreams with confidence and courage," the president said. In his message on social media, Prime Minister Modi said, "Congratulations to the Indian Women's Football Team on winning the SAFF Women's Championship 2026."



PM LAUDS MAJOR ABHILASHA BARAK FOR UN AWARD

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday congratulated Major Abhilasha Barak on being conferred the UN Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award and said the honour is a recognition of her exemplary service and also of India's longstanding contribution to UN peacekeeping efforts. Major Barak, currently serving with the UN mission in Lebanon, has been honoured with the award for her outreach efforts with women and girls during her deployment in the West Asian nation. She is also the first woman combat helicopter pilot of the Indian Army. "Congratulations to Major Abhilasha Barak on being conferred the UN Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award," Modi said in a post on social media.

After farmers' stir, land acquisition process for Gadchiroli airport, projects put on hold

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gadchiroli

The land acquisition process for a proposed airport and industrial area in Gadchiroli in Maharashtra was temporarily put on hold after more than 3000 farmers held an agitation at the district collectorate, officials said on Sunday.

These farmers, who took part in the sit-in strike for the past couple of days, claimed their fertile lands were being acquired for the airport as well as industrial projects in Charmorshi.

Officials said the Maharashtra government, on May 12 this year, gave administrative and financial sanction of approximately Rs 104 crore to acquire 311.81 hectares of land, including those under Government, private and forest department control, from Shirapur Chak, Guruvala, Hirapur Chak, Guruvala, Hirapur and Rakhi villages for building an



airport in the district.

"The Government's attempt to acquire land by issuing direct orders for these projects, without obtaining consent of the original landowners, is highly unjust and unacceptable. The Government must immediately revoke all land acquisition orders," Communist Party of India district general secretary Amol Markawar said.

Several acres of land in five villages will be taken over for the airport, and 14

Revanth's Hitler remark on HYDRAA sparks political row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy's remarks that he drew inspiration from Nazi dictator Adolf Hitler while naming HYDRAA have sparked a political row with the BRS and the BJP, strongly criticising him.

Speaking at an event in Bengaluru on Saturday, Revanth Reddy had said he decided to establish HYDRAA after observing widespread encroachments of lakes and waterbodies.

"...poor people encroaching on lakes and nalas, I can understand. Nowadays, rich people are encroaching on waterbodies because of their farmhouses and connecting their drainage to the waterbodies. I have noticed all those issues. Then I decided to establish one task force—HYDRAA".

He had further said, "Hydra, the word is Hitler's favourite word. His core team was called Hydra, who can assassinate anyone. So, I have taken inspiration from Hitler, and I have named it HYDRAA".



The Chief Minister said he established the organisation—HYDRAA with its Commissioner, a senior IPS officer.

Hydra is a fictional organisation from Marvel Comics, which served as the deep

science division of the Nazis during the second World War.

Reacting to the Telangana CM's remarks, Union Coal and Mines Minister G Kishan Reddy, in a post on 'X', said Congress "dangerous Hitler, Emergency Mindset" out in the open — yet again.

"Revanth Reddy, now openly boasting that Hitler

Congress and JMM to contest one Rajya Sabha seat each in Jharkhand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress and JMM have decided to contest one seat each in the upcoming Rajya Sabha polls in Jharkhand following an agreement between the leaders of the two alliance partners at a breakfast meeting.

The Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) had earlier indicated that it would contest both the Rajya Sabha seats and announced the name of one candidate, while the Congress, too, named its candidate for one of the two seats. Elections for the Rajya Sabha seats will



be held on June 18.

"We have resolved the issue, and now JMM and Congress will contest one seat each," a senior leader involved in the discussions said.

Sources said the agreement was reached during a meeting between Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren and Congress observers Bhupesh Baghel and Ajay Sharma over breakfast.

Structural deficiencies found at Khan Global Studies in Patna during fire audit: Officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar Police on Sunday found several structural deficiencies at Khan Global Studies (KGS) in Patna during a fire audit and said notice will be issued to the institute for rectifying the shortcomings within a week, officials said.

The audit was conducted days after a fire at a private hospital in Muzaffarpur district claimed at least seven lives.

KGS is a Patna-based coaching institute founded by educator Faisal Khan, popularly known as Khan Sir, and is known for preparing students for competitive and Government recruitment examinations

"We have found deficiencies here at KGS during the fire audit, and a notice will be issued soon. If they fail to comply within a week, appropriate action will be taken," assistant district fire

inspired him to create HYDRAA and is comparing his demolitions in Hyderabad to those in war-torn countries like Iran and Israel, echoing his leader Rahul Gandhi's language," Kishan Reddy said.

He further alleged from "Emergency to Hitler - Congress has always muzzled people", demanding that the CM tender an unconditional apology to the people of Telangana.

The BRS in a post on 'X' described Revanth Reddy as the "new Hitler", alleging homes of lakhs of poor "demolished".

The Telangana Government established Hyderabad Disaster Response and Asset Protection Agency (HYDRAA) in July 2024 to protect Government assets, such as lakes, from encroachments and other illegal activities.

The agency has been carrying out operations to remove encroachments and has demolished several alleged illegal structures.

TVK Govt may not last even 3 months: Stalin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

DMK president MK Stalin on Sunday claimed that the TVK Government in Tamil Nadu, headed by Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, may not survive beyond three months.

Vijay was sworn in as the CM of Tamil Nadu in May, ushering in the first non-DMK, non-AIADMK Government in the State in 60 years.

Speaking at an event where former VCK MLA Panaiyur Babu and his supporters joined the DMK, the former CM said, "I need not say much about the kind of Government currently in power. When it assumed office, I had said I would not criticise it for six months. However, there is now a fear that circumstances may force me to speak sooner."

"Many people are already talking about it, and criticism is mounting. It is not a question of six months, five months or even four months. The question now is whether this Government will last even three months," Stalin said.



Senior Congress leader P Chidambaram has said that his party extended support to the TVK only after informing the DMK leadership.

The Congress, which was allied with DMK to contest in the April 23 Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, was the first party to offer support with five MLAs to TVK to enable the formation of the Government.

"We want to prevent another election if TVK fails to secure a majority in the House. This was a wider feeling among alliance partners. Even people do not want another election," he told a private news channel on Saturday.

Claiming that the Congress also informed the alliance partners, including CPI, VCK and IUML, about its decision to support the TVK government, Chidambaram

said, "the only difference is that we have announced the support to TVK one day before allies did".

Soon after the alliance's poll debacle, the DMK youth wing, led by Udhayanidhi Stalin, organised a meeting and passed a resolution, accusing the Congress of "betraying" the DMK.

Senior DMK leader TR Baalu also alleged that the Congress betrayed the people who voted for the alliance.



"It is in this context that you have joined this movement today," he added, urging the new entrants to cooperate with the party in all its organisational activities.

Stalin also urged the newly inducted cadres not to criticise the parties they were previously associated with.

Quoting party founder CN Annadurai, he said, "Anna famously said that even the jasmine in a rival's garden has fragrance. There is no need to underestimate anyone."

Uttarakhand: Over 31 lakh pilgrims visit, 161 fatalities so far this season

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dehradun

More than 31 lakh pilgrims have visited Uttarakhand since the Char Dham Yatra began in April, while 161 fatalities have been reported among the devotees during the ongoing pilgrimage season, officials said on Sunday.

According to the latest report from the State Emergency Operation Centre, Kedarnath Dham recorded the highest footfall with 11,05,676 pilgrims since opening on April 22.

Badrinath Dham has followed with 9,08,619 visitors since April 23.

Gangotri shrine received 5,28,406 pilgrims, Yamunotri temple recorded 5,07,421, and Sri Hemkund Sahib registered 55,411 visitors. Gaumukh recorded 4,697



trekkers, who were included in the Gangotri totals.

On Saturday, 61,262 pilgrims arrived at the shrines, along with 5,511 vehicles.

Officials said 2,89,918 vehicles have used the yatra routes since the start of the season. The State reported 161 casualties among pilgrims since April 19.

Medical issues and failing health accounted for 152 of these deaths; eight pilgrims died due to other reasons, and one person died from natural causes, said the official data.

During the pilgrimage, Yamunotri reported the highest toll with 78 deaths, followed by Kedarnath (47), Badrinath (20), Gangotri (16),

Assam's Manas National Park lost 60% grasslands

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Assam's Manas National Park & Tiger Reserve (MNPTR) on Sunday rolled out the state's first grass nursery to protect the endangered ecosystem, as it has lost more than 60 per cent of the park's grasslands over the past 35 years.

The park authorities also released 15 captive-bred pygmy hogs, the world's smallest and rarest wild pig, into the forest under the Pygmy Hog Conservation Programme (PHCP).

"In a major step towards securing the future of Assam's endangered grassland ecosystems, the state's first dedicated grass nursery was inaugurated at Bansbari Range of Manas National Park," MNPTR said in a statement.

The nursery has been developed over an area of 7.5 bigha (approximately one hectare) with financial



support from the State Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority (CAMPA), it added.

"The nursery will serve as a long-term seed source for grassland restoration and expansion across Manas and other protected areas of Assam," MNPTR said.

The initiative comes at a crucial time for Manas as recent assessments indicate that the reserve has lost

over 60 per cent of its historical grassland cover during the last three and a half decades, it added.

"Grasslands that once covered approximately 384 sq km (45 per cent of the landscape) in 1990 have declined to about 155 sq km (18 per cent) today, primarily due to invasive species, woodland encroachment, altered river dynamics and prolonged interruption of habitat management in

earlier decades," MNPTR said. It is estimated that nearly 6 sq km of grassland is lost annually, underscoring the urgent need for restoration interventions, it added.

The project marks another important milestone in Manas' ongoing efforts to restore one of Asia's most important riverine grassland ecosystems and secure the ecological integrity of the UNESCO Natural World Heritage Site for future generations.

In the new project, a total of 16 species of native grasses were collected from different habitats within Manas since November 2025 and raised in specially prepared nursery beds.

"The nursery was established in May 2026 and is expected to play a critical role in supporting large-scale ecological restoration efforts," the authorities said.

These alluvial grasslands form the ecological back-

bone of Manas and support globally threatened wildlife, including the pygmy hog, Bengal florican, hispid hare, one-horned rhinoceros, wild water buffalo, swamp deer, Asian elephant and tiger.

Speaking on the occasion, Assam Principal Chief Conservator of Forest (Wildlife) and Chief Wildlife Warden Vinay Gupta stated that restoration of grasslands is among the highest conservation priorities for Manas National Park.

"The newly established grass nursery will ensure a sustainable supply of native grass species required for habitat restoration, invasive species management and recovery of critical wildlife habitats," he added.

Meanwhile, 15 captive-bred pygmy hogs were released in the same function into the Kuribael grasslands of Manas National Park under the Pygmy Hog Conservation Programme.



officer Ajay Kumar Sharma told reporters.

Sharma said deficiencies were found in the fire alarm system, while a fire pump had not been installed. The capacity of the overhead water tank was also inadequate, and there was no fixed fire-fighting system, he added.

Despite repeated attempts, officials of KGS could not be reached for comment.

Referring to the statewide

audit drive, Sharma said, "In light of the recent fire incidents in Delhi and Muzaffarpur, a large-scale fire audit and investigation is being conducted for all hotels, hospitals and various institutes. Notices are being issued to them to install proper fire safety systems and obtain certificates from the fire department. They also need to submit an electrical load analysis for the

appliances installed in their buildings."

According to a statement issued by the governor's secretariat, fire safety audits and the related compliance process have been completed in 1,679 out of Bihar's 1,943 hospitals and in 3,744 out of the state's 4,020 hotels.

The remaining hospitals and hotels have been directed to ensure compliance with fire safety standards and other provisions prescribed by the Government at the earliest, it added.

BJP Govt best positioned to develop Jharkhand: Nabin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Sunday said the party, under its leadership and with the support of dedicated workers, was best positioned to ensure the development and progress of Jharkhand.

He said Jharkhand's people had earlier supported the BJP and credited the party with playing a key role in the creation of the State.

"Looking at the current situation, it appears that only the leadership and dedicated workers of the BJP are best positioned to ensure the development and progress of Jharkhand," Nabin told reporters here.

He was on a two-day visit to the state and participated in several organisational events during his stay.

Nabin said the State remained a stronghold of the BJP and expressed confidence that the party would



BJP National President Nitin Nabin meets Jharkhand BJP president Aditya Sahu in Ranchi, Jharkhand

return to power in the State.

"I met party workers during various programmes, and the enthusiasm with which they engaged with us makes me believe that Jharkhand will herald a bright

future for the BJP. We will succeed in strengthening the party's roots here," he said.

During the day, he chaired a joint meeting with state BJP president Aditya Sahu, district presidents, in-charges, and

State-level teams at the party headquarters in Ranchi.

Addressing the meeting, Nabin said the current organisational structure has been prepared with an eye on the 2029 elections.

"This team will lead the upcoming elections. Taking lessons from past elections, every party worker must gear up for 2029 right away," he said, according to a party statement.

Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of 'Viksit Bharat-2047', he said the goal of a developed India could be achieved only through strengthening the organisation at the booth level and ensuring full commitment from party workers.

Nabin also visited the residence of his maternal aunt, Shobha Sinha, following her death on Sunday morning, and expressed condolences to the bereaved family. He also planted a tree in her memory under the party's 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign.

Goa CM Sawant meets Shah in Delhi to discuss ST seats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant on Sunday met Union Home Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi on the issue of reserving seats for Scheduled Tribes in the State Assembly.

Sawant was accompanied by Union Minister Shripad Naik, Assembly Speaker Ganesh Gaonkar, State Art and Culture Minister Ramesh Tawadkar, Goa BJP president Damodar Naik and MLA Govind Gaude.

"Called on Hon'ble Union Home Minister Shri Amit Shah ji in New Delhi today to discuss the implementation of ST Reservation in the Goa Legislative Assembly," Sawant said in a post on X, adding he was grateful for



Union Home Minister Amit Shah, centre, being greeted by Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant, second left and others during a meeting

Shah's "positive assurance and full cooperation in ensuring implementation of this important matter".

Parliament has passed The Readjustment of Representation of Scheduled Tribes in Assembly Constituencies of the State of Goa Bill 2024.

During the visit to the national Capital, Sawant also

met Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to discuss recruitment related concerns at the National Institute of Technology in Goa.

He also met Union minister Ashwini Vaishnaw to discuss key projects under the railway ministry and ministry of electronics and information technology.

4,800 illegal immigrants sent back to Bangladesh: Suvendu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday said around 4,800 illegal immigrants have been sent to Bangladesh from holding centres set up in the State's border districts, and around 836 such people are awaiting deportation from these facilities.

Adhikari asserted that illegal immigration was a big issue, and said his Government has already handed over land to the BSF to erect around 100 km of fencing, out of the 556 km required to secure the India-Bangladesh border.

The land handover is a continuous process and is necessary for the security of the country, he said, adding that securing the international

boundary is the state government's priority.

"We have handed over to the BSF around 100 km stretch of land out of 556 km required for fencing, and prioritised the Chicken's Neck corridor in north Bengal," the chief minister said, while addressing a preparatory meeting for the BJP's special training camp.

The 'Chicken's Neck', officially known as the Siliguri Corridor, is a narrow stretch of land - about 20-22 km wide and nearly 60 km long - in north Bengal that connects the rest of India with its northeastern states. It is considered a critical and sensitive lifeline from both security and strategic perspectives.

West Bengal, among all Indian states, shares the longest international boundary with Bangladesh, stretch-



ing 2,217 km, out of a total of 4,096 km. Stating that his Government has started deporting illegal immigrants, who do not fall under the Citizenship Amendment Act, as per a law of the Union government, Adhikari said, "These people are being handed over to the BSF directly."

payers' expense. "Around 4,800 illegal immigrants have been sent back from holding centres set up in the state's border districts," Adhikari said, adding that 836 such people are awaiting deportation from those facilities.

Pointing to the flow of people at the Hakimpur border in North 24 Parganas district, Adhikari said that many illegal immigrants have already left on their own.

"The demography of Bengal has changed," the chief minister claimed, adding that the BJP had made infiltration from Bangladesh and demographic change the biggest issues in the West Bengal assembly election, and accused the Mamata Banerjee-led party of being complacent on both issues for political reasons.

LPG price hike inevitable: Pralhad Joshi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dharwad (Karnataka)

Union Minister Pralhad Joshi said on Sunday that the Centre also feels "very sad and sorry" over the hike in gas cylinder prices, but described it as "inevitable" given the prevailing global situation.

The domestic cooking gas LPG price has been raised by ₹29 per cylinder, marking the second increase in three months as State-owned fuel retailers continue to grapple with elevated global energy costs. "We also feel very sad and sorry about the hike in gas cylinder prices, but before criticising, everyone should understand the situation in the entire world. The world is reeling under very serious crises," Joshi said, speaking to reporters here.

"No transshipment is happening, and LPG is available from a very limited number of sources," Union Minister for Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, and New and Renewable Energy, said. Aimed at ensuring that no hardship is caused to LPG and petrol/diesel consumers, the Government of



Union Minister Pralhad Joshi

India under Prime Minister Narendra Modi is trying to enhance procurement resources, the minister said.

He added that procurement is happening from countries that are quite far from India.

"Transportation costs are high, the base cost is also high, and insurance costs have increased due to 40-45 days of transshipment. So we are also equally worried about the common man, but at the same time, the price hike is inevitable," he added. The increase follows

a ₹60-per-cylinder hike on March 7 after the conflict in West Asia disrupted global energy supplies and drove up international fuel prices. State-run oil marketing companies were estimated to be losing about ₹703 per LPG cylinder sold before the latest revision.

The Union Government said Indian households "continue to pay among the lowest prices" for cooking gas globally despite a sharp rise in international PG prices triggered by disruptions due to the West Asia crisis that

began on February 28 following a joint attack by the US-Israel on Iran. In a statement, the Government said the cost of supplying a domestic LPG cylinder has risen to more than ₹1,600 following a surge in international prices that followed the outbreak of war in West Asia.

India's LPG import costs are linked to the Saudi Contract Price (CP), the global benchmark for the fuel. The benchmark has risen about 46 per cent since February after disruptions linked to the Strait of Hormuz tightened supplies from the Gulf region, it added.

Alleging that the Congress Government in Karnataka is plagued by "corruption, nepotism, and factionalism," Joshi took a dig, saying that "internal dissatisfaction," within the ruling party was evident.

He added that soon after Chief Minister DK Shivakumar assumed office, one minister resigned and a few others publicly expressed their displeasure. "The situation itself shows that all is not well within the Government and the administration," he added.

Vijayan criticises LPG price hike, calls it anti-people

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Leader of Opposition in the Kerala Assembly, Pinarayi Vijayan, on Sunday criticised the latest hike in domestic LPG prices, alleging that it would further burden ordinary households already reeling under rising living costs.

In a statement, the CPI(M) veteran said the Centre should immediately withdraw what he called an "anti-people" decision to raise the price of domestic cooking gas cylinders by ₹29.

He pointed out that this was the second increase in domestic LPG prices within three months, noting that the price of a 14.2-kg cylinder has now risen to ₹951. The Centre had increased the price by ₹60 per cylinder on March 7, he said.



Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan

Vijayan alleged that a series of decisions affecting people's lives had followed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent call for citizens to be prepared to make sacrifices.

The former chief minister also expressed concern over the impact of rising fuel prices on various sectors of the economy.

He claimed that the sharp increase in commer-

cial LPG prices had pushed the hotel industry into crisis, while petrol and diesel prices had risen by a total of ₹7.50 per litre since mid-May. CNG prices, too, had gone up by ₹6 per kilogram, he said.

Calling for immediate intervention by the state Government, Vijayan urged it to take steps to provide relief to the public from escalating prices.

He also reiterated his demand that the State Government forego additional tax revenue from petroleum price hikes to shield people from the worsening inflationary burden.

Vijayan urged both the Centre and the State Government to review what he termed their "negative and anti-people" approach on the issue and take measures to ease public hardship.

Speaker Birla calls for efforts towards a developed India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Sunday outlined a collaborative blueprint for making India into a developed country by 2047, emphasising that economic development needs to be inclusive.

Addressing an event of the Maheshwari community here, Birla emphasised that entrepreneurship and nation-building must progress hand in hand to ensure that economic growth is both inclusive and sustainable.

According to the Lok Sabha Secretariat, the speaker asserted that development is meaningful only when its benefits reach the last person in



society and every citizen becomes an active participant in progress.

He said the national resolve for an 'Atmanirbhar Bharat' (self-reliant India) is infusing new energy into small, medium, and innovation-driven industries, which are vital for equitable growth.

Will ensure border villages not left behind on development front: J&K LG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Sunday said that India's true identity thrives in its border villages and expressed commitment to ensuring that the residents of these areas receive the same development, prosperity and opportunities as those living in major cities.

Addressing a gathering during his visit to Nangali village in Poonch district under the Vibrant Village Programme, Sinha said border villages are the nation's first glimpse and serve as proud gateways to the country.

"My resolve is unwavering. Our border villages deserve the exact same development and prosperity as our biggest towns and cities. I will not rest until every family on the border enjoys the same progress and opportunities as those in urban Jammu and Kashmir," he said.

The L-G asserted that the youth of border villages should have bright futures and equal opportunities, and that the world must view India's border villages not as the last settlements but as the beginning of a great national dream.

Sinha said every family living in Poonch's 133 border villages should experience the same pride, prosperity and hope enjoyed by residents of larger urban centres.

He said the administration would work tirelessly to transform these villages into symbols of development and prosperity.

Highlighting his vision for the region, Sinha said he wanted the youth of Nangali to dream as ambitiously as those in metropolitan cities and women in all 133 border villages to have access to the same opportunities available elsewhere.

"I want children across Poonch's border villages to grow up believing their village is not a place to leave, but a place to build their future," he said, adding that all these villages, including 18 strategic villages covered under Vibrant Village Phase-II, should emerge as centres of opportunity and growth.

The LG also reviewed ongoing development works and interacted with residents and government officials during the visit.

Referring to the developmental initiatives undertaken under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Sinha said significant progress had



Jammu and Kashmir Lt Governor Manoj Sinha paying tribute to Lieutenant Beereswar Goswami, who lost his life while undertaking operational duties during an anti-terror operation in Rajouri district at the air force station in Jammu on Sunday

been achieved in border areas over the past six years. According to him, around 20 per cent of families in Poonch's border villages have moved above the poverty line during this period.

He said infrastructure development has resulted in 94 per cent road connectivity, 98 per cent telecom coverage and 100 per cent

healthcare coverage in these areas. He further said that family incomes have increased by 25 per cent while outmigration has declined by six per cent, adding that the administration's objective is to achieve saturation of all welfare schemes and ensure that no household is left behind.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah Ji offering puja at Lord Ayyappa temple in RK Puram, New Delhi and also inaugurated the newly built SABAREESAM Complex

PIONEER PHOTO



Editor's
TAKE

Can the Khanal visit reset Indo-Nepal ties?

Nepal's Foreign Minister arrives in New Delhi with unusual candour and a concrete agenda. The real test is whether rhetoric can be converted into results

Nepal's Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal arrived in New Delhi with something unusual in diplomatic circles: candour. On his first visit representing Prime Minister Balen Shah's Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) government, Khanal skipped the customary pleasantries and acknowledged plainly that Nepal had wasted years of growth while India surged ahead. That kind of honesty from Kathmandu is itself a departure from the past. Indo-Nepal relations have long been strained by geography, identity, and politics. Border disputes – most notably the Kalapani-Lipulekh-Limpiyadhura row of 2020 – left deep distrust. Past Nepali governments, trapped in unstable coalitions, found it convenient to weaponise anti-India sentiment for domestic audiences. The result was a relationship perpetually held hostage to Nepal's fractious electoral politics.

The RSP's rise – driven by youth-led protests against corruption – changes this calculus. Unlike Nepal's older parties, the RSP carries no decades-long ideological baggage toward Beijing or New Delhi. Khanal put it plainly: his party came from professional, non-political backgrounds, free from the ideological reflexes of the past. That is a welcome break from the past. A government that doesn't need the anti-India card for political survival is one India can genuinely work with.

The agenda Khanal brought to meetings with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and NSA Doval was refreshingly practical. Energy concerns tops the list – Nepal's vast hydropower potential remains deeply underutilised. A comprehensive sectoral framework, including a tripartite power-export arrangement involving Bangladesh through Indian transmission lines, could transform Nepal's finances and South Asia's bid for clean energy. Rail links between Janakpur and Ayodhya, new air routes through Bhairahawa and Pokhara – would unlock Nepal's landlocked economy. A UPI-based payments agreement and AI collaboration on regional languages complete an agenda that is, crucially, achievable in a short span of time. Yet hard questions remain. The boundary dispute hasn't been resolved. No lasting partnership can indefinitely avoid a territorial disagreement with deep nationalist resonance on both sides. India, too, must resist its historical paternalism: the assumption that Nepal's foreign policy must align with New Delhi's preferences, a notion that smacks of big-brother-attitude.

Nepal has seen governments fall with dizzying frequency. The RSP is young, and Shah has yet to prove his reformist instincts can survive the grind of governance. The real test won't be the MOUs signed during the visit, but whether they are actually implemented on the ground. What this moment demands from both capitals is institutional depth. Fast-track the energy framework. Invest in Nepal's human capital through the proposed IIT and AIIMS. Economic cooperation is the best glue both countries can have to cement the relations. The RSP arrived without past baggage. History doesn't dissolve in one visit. But this window – perhaps the clearest in a decade – deserves to be seized with urgency by both sides.

Fighting air pollution with urban greening

Planting the right trees in the right places isn't just about beautifying the capital city of Delhi – it's about building a living, breathing defence against one of the world's worst urban air pollution crises



MEENAKSHI
DHOTE

Trees, shrubs, and grasses do far more than add greenery to grey cityscapes. Vegetation intercepts airborne particles on leaves, branches, bark, and stems, physically reducing the amount of dust and pollutants residents inhale. Dense canopies stabilise exposed soil, cutting down on wind-blown dust resuspension - one of Delhi's major pollution contributors. Plants also absorb gaseous pollutants such as oxides of sulphur and nitrogen directly through their stomata. Additionally, trees add surface roughness that promotes atmospheric turbulence, which in turn prevents pollutant accumulation by encouraging greater dispersal and dilution. Green areas further stimulate the sedimentation of aerosols and dust particles. As a bonus, neighbourhoods with dense tree cover tend to run several degrees cooler than bare urban zones, delivering cleaner air and cooler streets simultaneously.

Research conducted across Delhi supports these benefits. Studies found that PM10 and PM05 concentrations were significantly higher in less vegetated areas like Anand Vihar and Jahangirpuri compared to greener localities such as Mandir Marg and Sri Aurobindo Marg. Well-designed vegetation barriers have also been shown to meaningfully reduce local PM5 levels near plantation zones, and dense shrub barriers around schools, hospitals, and pedestrian areas offer added protection by intercepting dust precisely at breathing height.

Choosing the right species

Not all plants are created equal when it comes to pollution tolerance. Some species are highly sensitive to pollutants and serve best as early-warning bioindicators, while others are hardy enough to withstand polluted conditions and actively help reduce the pollution load. The Air Pollution Tolerance Index (APTI) - calculated using a formula involving a plant's ascorbic acid content, total chlorophyll, leaf extract pH, and relative water content - provides a scientific basis for species selection. Combined with biological and socio-economic factors, this yields an Anticipated Performance Index (API) that guides Green Belt development decisions. A 2024 study by the Indian Agricultural Research Institute (IARI) identified Peepal (Ficus religiosa) as one of Delhi's most pollution-tolerant tree species, followed closely by Karanj (Pongamia pinnata). Other recommended species for Delhi-NCR include Neem, Arjun, Jamun, Banyan, Shahtoot, Imli, Mango, and Amaltas - all valued for their high dust-capturing capacity, resilience



THE SCIENCE IS CLEAR AND THE TOOLS ARE AVAILABLE. WHAT REMAINS IS THE COLLECTIVE WILL TO PLANT NOT JUST FOR OPTICS, BUT WITH GENUINE PURPOSE

under polluted conditions, and climate suitability. For large-scale ecological restoration along the Yamuna floodplain, biodiversity parks, and the Delhi Ridge, native species like Arjun, Jamun, Karanj, and Imli are particularly well-suited, offering additional benefits such as groundwater recharge, carbon sequestration, and biodiversity conservation.

Greening roads and flyovers

Urban road infrastructure offers significant untapped potential for strategic greening. Narrow medians of 0.5-1.2 m can be seeded with grasses like Dhooab and Vetiver to stabilise soil and reduce dust resuspension. Medium medians of 1.2-3 m width suit single to triple rows of shrubs such as Bougainvillea and Nerium oleander, while those between 3-4 m can support layered combinations of shrubs, grasses, and small trees like Frangipani. Larger medians exceeding 4 m allow for full-scale planting of trees including Neem, Alstonia scholaris, Terminalia arjuna, Sheesham, and Karanj, combined with understory shrubs and grasses for maximum pollutant capture. Footpaths of 1.8 m width can be lined with shade-giving trees like Neem, Mango, and Terminalia arjuna, with native grasses planted in tree pits to bind soil. Even the underutilised spaces beneath flyovers can be put to work - climbers such as Vernonia grandiflora, Ficus scandens, Thunbergia grandiflora, and Ipomoea species can cover concrete surfaces, absorb pollutants, and introduce greenery into otherwise dead urban spaces.

Planning matters as much as planting

Experts are clear on one point: volume alone is not enough. Indiscriminate planting of large trees

without proper planning can actually worsen local air quality. Dense canopies in confined spaces like narrow street canyons may trap pollutants and restrict air circulation, leading to higher localised concentrations. Effective greening demands careful attention to species selection, spacing, and placement to ensure vegetation enhances pollutant dispersal rather than obstructing it. In Delhi's traffic-heavy corridors and densely built neighbourhoods, integrating trees with shrubs and grasses in a layered, planned manner is essential to maximise results.

Green belt design must also account for local climatic conditions, soil quality, water availability, and pollution load. Greening of adequate width and density using local species is strongly recommended - exotic species should be avoided to ensure easier maintenance and long-term survival. From a nursery perspective, sapling quality, transport, and early-stage care including tree guards, watering, and manuring are all critical to successful establishment. Notably, once established, native species typically require minimal maintenance.

A greener commitment

Urban greening is not a silver bullet, but it is an indispensable piece of Delhi's clean air puzzle. When vegetation is planned scientifically - the right species, the right spacing, the right location - it functions as a living filter, a dust barrier, a temperature regulator, and an ecological anchor all at once. The science is clear and the tools are available. What remains is the collective will to plant not just for optics, but with genuine purpose - turning Delhi's streets, medians, and open spaces into a green infrastructure that works as hard as the city itself.

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The Pioneer

New bridge between corporate funds and environmental action



VIVEK
SAXENA

2ND OPINION

World Environment Day 2026, observed on 5 June under the theme "Inspired by Nature. For Climate. For Our Future," was indeed timely and pertinent. Just days earlier, on 27 May 2026, the Government of India introduced the ZCZP-CSR Reform — a policy that could quietly transform how corporate money reaches environmental causes across the country.

Picture a small organisation in Haryana restoring ponds, planting trees, and protecting local wildlife. It has the will but lacks the funding. Now picture a large corporation with crores allocated for CSR activities but no reliable channel to support such grassroots groups. ZCZP — Zero Coupon Zero Principal — is designed to connect these two worlds. Despite its technical name, the concept is simple. Companies can route a portion of their CSR funds through

the Social Stock Exchange (SSE), regulated by SEBI, to verified non-profit organisations. The funds carry no interest and are not returned — essentially a structured, government-recognised donation through the stock market system. Funding can support projects for up to three years, and all transactions remain transparent and accountable. Under Section 135 of the Companies Act, 2013, companies with a net worth above ₹500 crore, turnover above ₹1,000 crore, or net profit above ₹5 crore must spend 2 per cent of their average net profit on CSR. The new rules allow up to 10 per cent of that CSR budget to flow through ZCZP, while 90 per cent must continue funding direct, ground-level work. Companies must also declare ZCZP in their CSR policies and report it to the Ministry of Corporate Affairs — non-compliance will be treated as a violation.

This reform is the latest link in a chain of environmental initiatives under Prime Minister Modi. The journey began with Mission LiFE, launched at COP26 in 2021, encouraging citizens to adopt small habits — saving electricity, reducing plastic, conserving water. Over 6 crore people have since joined the movement. The IEA estimates such collective action could cut global carbon emissions by 2 billion tonnes annually by 2030.

The *Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam* campaign followed, urging people and companies alike to plant trees in honour of their mothers. Then came the Green Credit Programme at COP28

in 2023, rewarding conservation actions — tree plantation, water conservation, waste management — with credits companies can use in their ESG reporting. ZCZP now gives these efforts a solid financial backbone. Today's investors look beyond profits. ESG performance — Environmental, Social, and Governance — shapes how companies are valued. When ZCZP funds support afforestation, mangrove restoration, or river conservation, they directly strengthen a company's environmental credentials. Since SSE-listed organisations follow strict accountability norms, companies also get verified records, supporting SEBI's mandatory BRSR Core reporting for the top 1,000 listed firms.

For conservation workers and forest organisations struggling to survive without stable funding, this opens a genuine new door. One caution remains: greenwashing. Some companies may chase ESG ratings without creating real impact.

The true measure of this reform will not be found in annual reports. It will be seen in healthier forests, cleaner rivers, and thriving wildlife. India's answer to what are we giving back? — is a system that finally makes corporate responsibility and environmental recovery work together. The return this time is not for shareholders. It is for the earth.

The writer is IFS, Haryana Cadre, Former Country Director and Country Representative, IUCN

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SAFEGUARDING THE INTEGRITY OF EXAMINATIONS

The recent protest at Jantar Mantar, attended by a large number of candidates and their supporters, has drawn national attention to the alleged paper leak controversy. The demonstration reflects the deep anxiety among aspirants who believe that such incidents undermine the fairness and credibility of competitive examinations.

For millions of young Indians, examinations represent the gateway to educational opportunities and professional advancement. Students invest years of hard work, dedication and sacrifice in preparing for these tests. Any suspicion of malpractice not only raises questions about the integrity of the examination process but also severely affects the morale and confidence of deserving candidates. Feelings of disappointment and uncertainty

are inevitable when transparency is compromised.

It is imperative that the authorities concerned address the issue with urgency, transparency and accountability. A fair and independent investigation must be conducted, and those found guilty of wrongdoing should face stringent action.

Simultaneously, stronger safeguards, enhanced technological security measures and robust monitoring mechanisms should be introduced to prevent such incidents in future.

Protecting the sanctity of public examinations is essential to preserving public trust. Decisive action and meaningful reforms will reassure students that merit and hard work continue to be rewarded fairly.

RUKMA SHARMA | JALANDHAR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Progress in reducing infant mortality

The decline in Haryana's Infant Mortality Rate (IMR) from 28 to 24 deaths per 1,000 live births over the past five years, as highlighted in the Sample Registration System Report 2024, is an encouraging indicator of improvements in the state's healthcare system. Achieving parity with the national average reflects sustained efforts to strengthen maternal and child healthcare services. The nearly 14 per cent reduction in IMR has been made possible through targeted interventions and investments in healthcare infrastructure. Initiatives such as the expansion of Special Newborn Care Units, Newborn Stabilisation Units, Nutrition Rehabilitation Centres, Kangaroo Mother Care facilities and Home-Based Newborn Care services have played a significant role in improving neonatal outcomes.

Increased institutional deliveries and enhanced access to quality healthcare have further contributed to this achievement. The decline in Haryana's IMR from 41 to 24 over the past decade demonstrates the positive impact of consistent public health policies and community-based healthcare initiatives. However, there remains scope for improvement through continued investment in healthcare infrastructure, awareness programmes and strengthening services in rural areas. Sustaining this momentum will be crucial in ensuring brighter future for every child.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Political upheavals reflect dynamism

Recent political developments in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu highlight the fluid and evolving nature of democratic politics in India. Reports of internal rebellion and mass defections within the Trinamool Congress following its electoral setback underscore how electoral defeats often trigger introspection, leadership challenges and organisational restructuring within political parties.

Similarly, the reported fragmentation of the DMK-led alliance in Tamil Nadu and the emergence of new political alignments indicate that coalition politics remains dynamic and responsive to changing political realities. Political partnerships are frequently reassessed in the aftermath of elections, with parties seeking to redefine their strategies and priorities.

The resignation of BJP leader K. Annamalai and his decision to launch a new political movement centred ethical leadership further demonstrate that democratic systems allow space for alternative political visions.

While these transitions may create short-term uncertainty, they are also reminders that political organisations must continuously adapt to public expectations and intercal aspirations. Ultimately, democratic vitality lies in the ability of institutions and parties to evolve through peaceful and constitutional processes.

CK SURESH IYER | BENGALURU

BAL GOVIND | NOIDA

India’s green heritage: Eco-villages, and the path to a sustainable future

In today’s rapidly evolving technological era, the challenge before us is both urgent and inspiring: how do we build a future that balances innovation with nature, and growth with sustainability? India’s answer is emerging clearly through the rise of eco-villages, LEED-certified green buildings, and renewable energy initiatives



T SENTHIL SIVA SUBRAMANIAN

Across India, eco-villages are rising as powerful models of sustainable, community-driven living. These are not utopian experiments - they are thriving settlements that integrate ancient wisdom with modern technology to create healthier, happier, and more resilient ways of life.

Auroville, Tamil Nadu is perhaps India’s most iconic eco-village - a universal township dedicated to sustainable living for over five decades. Born in 1960 as a visionary concept and championed by the Government of India, Auroville received a landmark unanimous resolution from UNESCO in 1966, recognising its international significance for the well-being of humanity. Today, it continues to pioneer models of conscious, ecological living that inspire communities worldwide.

Govardhan Ecovillage (GEV), Maharashtra, nestled in the Sahyadri mountains near Mumbai, has earned international recognition from the United Nations World Tourism Organisation (UNWTO). Spanning 140 acres of lush green infrastructure, GEV seamlessly blends ancient Vedic knowledge with modern sustainable technologies. Visitors and residents alike benefit from organic farming, natural yoga practices, green-stay accommodations, and an Ayurvedic wellness centre rooted in Kerala’s traditional healing traditions.

Khonoma, Nagaland holds the distinction of being Asia’s first green village, driven entirely by the indigenous Angami tribe community. Famous for its sustainable jhum (shifting cultivation) agriculture, rich biodiversity, and community-led wildlife conservation, Khonoma demonstrates that indigenous knowledge and ecological stewardship go hand in hand.

Dayalbagh, Agra is a century-old green ecosystem, established in 1915, that has long embodied a holistic philosophy of life.

Dayalbagh follows a Six Sigma quality of life framework, built around three pillars: Quality, Values, and Attributes. Its carbon-free environment runs on solar power and battery-operated electric vehicles - entirely free of petrol and diesel. Community kitchens minimise waste, and affordable parabolic solar collectors are used for cooking. Dayalbagh has pioneered Agri-Photovoltaic technology, integrating solar energy systems directly with agricultural land. It has also cultivated medicinal herbs such as Abutilon indicum (Kanghi) and Acacia nilotica (Babool) for use in its own pharmacy and Ayurvedic treatments.

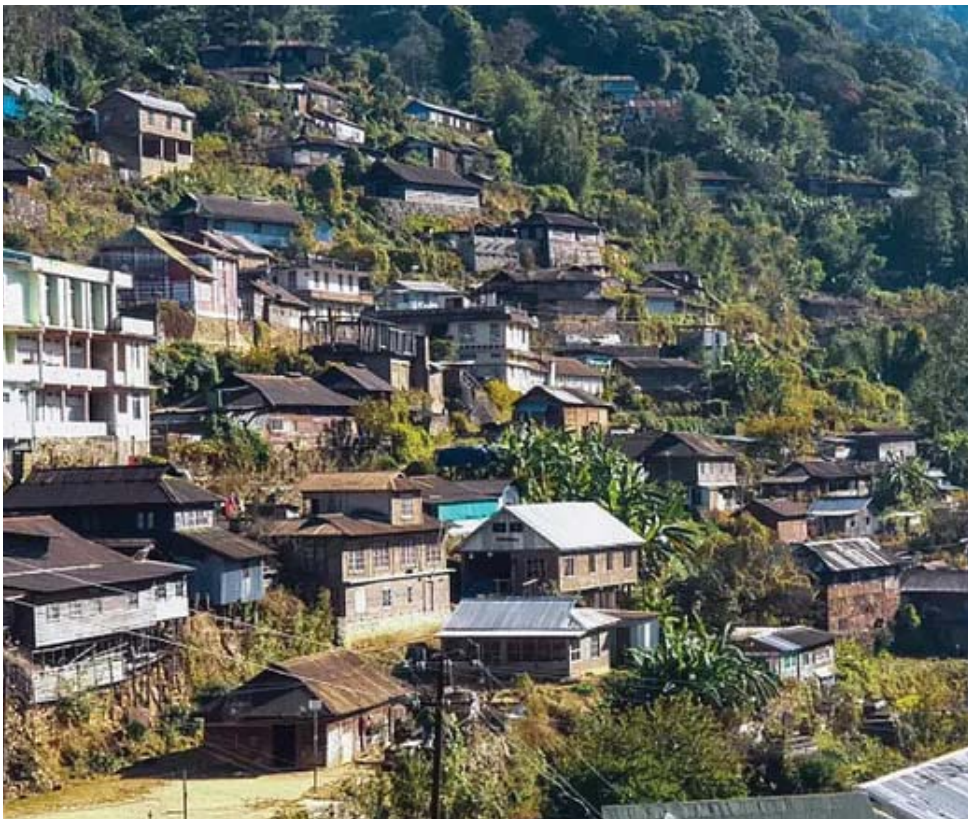
The Dayalbagh Educational Institute (Deemed University) has established a Centre of Excellence in Mushroom Technology, offering modular courses that have driven large-scale adoption of button and oyster mushroom cultivation among small-scale farmers in the Agra region - a true model of community-based learning and rural empowerment.

Mawlynnong, Meghalaya, famously known as “God’s Own Garden,” is recognised as one of Asia’s cleanest villages. Its remarkable cleanliness is sustained through disciplined waste segregation, traditional bamboo-based dustbins, and a strict zero-plastic policy - all managed entirely by community volunteers. It is a living proof that grassroots commitment can achieve what policy alone cannot.

Piplantri, Rajasthan has earned global recognition for a uniquely inspiring practice: planting 111 trees for every girl child born in the village. This movement has transformed Piplantri into a lush, thriving ecosystem while simultaneously celebrating the social value of women - a powerful union of environmental harmony and human dignity.

LEED Certification in India

India’s urban landscape is steadily transforming through the adoption of LEED (Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design) certification - the internationally recognised green building rating system originally developed by the United States Green Building Council (USGBC). In India, LEED certification



INDIA IS EMERGING AS A GLOBAL LEADER IN RENEWABLE ENERGY, WITH INNOVATIVE SOLUTIONS THAT PROTECT BOTH THE ENVIRONMENT AND THE LIVELIHOODS OF FARMERS

India is emerging as a global leader in renewable energy, with innovative solutions that protect both the environment and the livelihoods of farmers. Agri-Photovoltaic (Agri-PV) technology - which integrates solar panels directly over agricultural land - is being implemented across Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, and Gujarat. The Indian Agricultural Research Institute (ICAR) and the National Institute of Solar Energy, under the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE), have established a Centre of Excellence in Agri-PV to boost green productivity in rural areas. India has also made history by commissioning Asia’s largest floating solar project at Omkareshwar in Khandwa District, Madhya Pradesh - a testament to the nation’s bold renewable energy vision. On the wind energy front, the wind farm at Kayathar in Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu, operated under the National Institute of Wind Energy (NIWE), stands as a major national asset for clean, renewable power generation.

The author is Head Institute Industry Interface Programme Hindustan College of Science and Technology, Mathura

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is validated by GBCI India (Green Business Certification Inc.), ensuring that buildings meet rigorous standards for energy efficiency, water recycling and harvesting, and waste management.

Landmark LEED-certified buildings across India include Suzlon One Earth in Pune, the CII-Sohrabji Godrej Green Business Centre in Hyderabad, and ITC Green Centre in Gurgaon - each a benchmark of sustainable design and responsible construction. A particularly remarkable Indian innovation comes from ANT Studio, a pioneering architectural firm founded by Monish Siripurapu. The studio has developed a biomimicry-inspired passive cooling system using century-old Terracotta pot technology - a solution that is sustainable, affordable, and deeply rooted in India’s artisanal heritage. This project, which beautifully represents the STEAM approach (Science, Technology, Engineering, Arts, and Mathematics), received funding from the European Union and recognition under the UN Environment Programme.

Renewables: Agri-Photovoltaics, Solar, and Wind

India is emerging as a global leader in renewable energy, with innovative solutions that protect both the environment and the livelihoods of farmers. Agri-Photovoltaic (Agri-PV) technology - which integrates solar panels directly over agricultural land - is being implemented across Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, and Gujarat. The Indian Agricultural Research Institute (ICAR) and the National Institute of Solar Energy, under the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE), have established a Centre of Excellence in Agri-PV to boost green productivity in rural areas. India has also made history by commissioning Asia’s largest floating solar project at Omkareshwar in Khandwa District, Madhya Pradesh - a testament to the nation’s bold renewable energy vision. On the wind energy front, the wind farm at Kayathar in Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu, operated under the National Institute of Wind Energy (NIWE), stands as a major national asset for clean, renewable power generation.

Conclusion

India’s eco-villages, green buildings, and renewable energy initiatives collectively represent far more than environmental policy - they embody a philosophy of living in harmony with nature, drawing equally from ancient wisdom and modern innovation.

As India marches toward its goal of carbon neutrality by 2070 and its vision of a developed, self-reliant nation by 2047, these grassroots movements and technological milestones light the way. The health of our planet and the happiness of our people are inseparable - and India’s green heritage proves, powerfully, that a sustainable future is not only possible, but already taking root.

Why is welfare at the heart of Police reform?



AJAY SINGHAL

deserve the assurance that their institution will stand beside them at life’s most significant milestones.

The scheme with a purpose

On my first day as Director General of Police, Haryana, I announced the scheme. From April 1, 2026, every police employee from the lowest rank to the top cop will receive ₹2.5 lakh from the Police Welfare Fund for a daughter’s marriage. All police personnel support this fund through voluntary contributions, thereby demonstrating solidarity of the Haryana Police Parivar. The purpose is simple: ease the heavy, often unspoken wedding costs that many police families face. A Haryana constable earns a respectable salary after tough work and sacrifice, but this salary often does not meet the current costs of a wedding. Families borrow, sell assets, and accumulate debt. These anxieties rarely appear in reports but affect police households daily.

The Shagun Scheme takes this commitment further. Haryana Police has converted community halls within Police Lines across the state into dedicated banquet halls - dignified, affordable venues for weddings and social functions, open to police families at nominal cost and to the general public at accessible rates. This is not merely infrastructure. It is welfare with a social conscience.

Importantly, the Shagun Scheme is not an isolated welfare measure, but part of a broader philosophy-Our Force, Our Family-anchored in the belief that if society expects its police personnel to stand as the first line of defence, the institution must stand by them in moments of need, aspiration, and loss. We support welfare in many ways. Since 2022, over 19,000 staff have had regular health check-ups; annual health screenings are in place. Mental health support, counselling, de-addiction, yoga, fitness, and wellness programs help tackle both the mental and physical needs of policing. We offer interest-free loans for emergencies, education, and housing. Families of employees who die while in service receive up to ₹1.5 crore in insurance; over ₹188 crore has already been paid out by HDFC Bank. There are also compassionate jobs, ex gratia, martyr benefits, and death reliefs, etc., as part of our welfare measures.

Education has emerged as another cornerstone of welfare. Haryana Police’s network of 22 DAV Police Public Schools today educates over 23,000 children of police personnel, with support from fee concessions, scholarships, e-libraries, skill-development initiatives, and career guidance programmes. A recently launched hostel support scheme provides financial assistance of up to Rs. 50,000/- to personnel whose children pursue higher education away from home. We uphold operational dignity through weekly rest days, childcare leave, grievance systems, honorary promotions, and efforts to post couples together or women near their home districts. These steps provide a humane approach to workforce management. Significantly, Haryana remains the only state to provide a matching grant for police welfare, with the Chief Minister announcing a Rs 16 crore grant for the current year. Such initiatives recognise an enduring truth: a motivated police force is built not only through training and technology, but through trust, care, and institutional compassion.

The missing dimension in Police reform

Conversations on police reform focus on operations-new laws, accountability, technology, forensics, and faster investigations. These are essential, but we often overlook one key area: the welfare and well-being of police personnel. A police force’s effectiveness depends on more than its systems. Morale, dignity, and welfare of police personnel are essential. The force works best when its members feel valued and secure.

The link between welfare and performance is well established. The International Association of Chiefs of Police has noted that officers’ physical, psychological, and financial well-being directly influences professional conduct, institutional integrity, and public trust. Similarly, studies by India’s Bureau of Police Research and Development have highlighted dissatisfaction among personnel as a significant factor affecting public-police relations. Reform that ignores the individual behind the badge remains inherently incomplete. The reality is straightforward. A police officer burdened by financial worries, family concerns, or personal stress cannot be expected to perform with complete focus and composure. Anxiety carried from home to the workplace inevitably affects judgment, responsiveness, and public interactions. Over time, unresolved stress can lead to disengagement, frustration, and declining morale. The experience of police, paramilitary, and armed forces worldwide demonstrates a simple truth: the welfare of personnel is inseparable from the effectiveness of the force. Individuals can devote themselves fully to duty only when they are confident that their families are cared for and their own well-being matters to the institution they serve.

Today, in Haryana, a constable is saving for his daughter’s wedding. Now he knows the institution supports him. He can afford a police banquet hall. His child’s education is backed. If illness or crisis strikes, help is there. This assurance changes how he wears the uniform. He works with less anxiety and more pride. Police welfare is an evolving concept. Haryana Police’s humane approach is working to close the gap between what the institution demands of its personnel and what it offers in return. This is not sentimentalism. It is the practical logic of human dignity - a force that feels cared for, cares better. That is the foundation upon which genuine reform takes root. As we continue our journey, let us remember: true transformation begins by honouring those who serve and ensuring their well-being, which is always at the core of our reforms.



Beyond World Environment Day: Reclaiming our bond with nature



GAURAV SHARMA

At eleven at night, a city never truly sleeps. A young professional sits in a high-rise apartment, bathed in the cold blue light of a screen. Notifications cascade in - messages, deadlines, the relentless percussion of a digitally tethered life. Outside the window, however, a different kind of signal is being transmitted. A tree strains under an unseasonable summer.

A river carries plastic to the sea. The air - heavier, hotter, more toxic - presses against the glass. Unlike our devices, the Earth does not vibrate or ring. Yet its distress signals, for those willing to receive them, are no longer subtle.

Psychologists and ecologists speak of a modern affliction: ecological loneliness - the quiet desolation that settles upon human beings severed from the natural world to which they fundamentally belong. It may explain why so many today feel exhausted despite being more connected than at any point in history. The environmental crisis is not only unfolding around us. It is unfolding within us.

Present Realities, Not Predictions

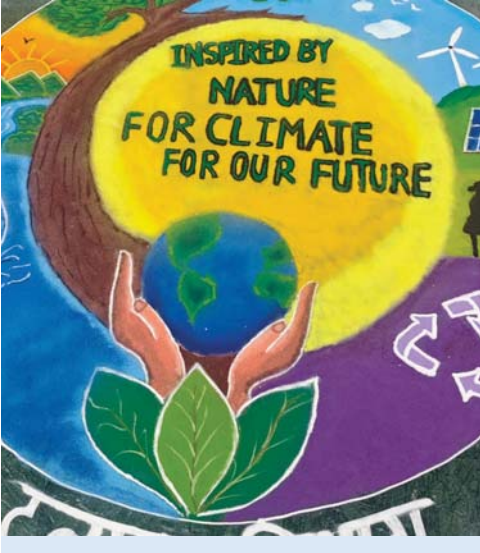
Temperatures in parts of northern India touched fifty degrees Celsius this April. Heatwaves, once the exception, are hardening into routine. Across

modern cities, air pollution continues to strain lungs and shorten lives. Plastics have achieved a terrible permanence - detected not only in ocean trenches but in river fish, agricultural soil, and common table salt. One-third of the world’s productive agricultural land has already been significantly degraded. Glaciers that took millennia to form are retreating within decades. These are not projections. They are present conditions. Yet environmental degradation is still discussed as somebody else’s problem - a matter for governments, scientists, and international summits.

The pandemic challenged that assumption. In those years, ordinary citizens altered the most intimate habits of their daily lives for strangers, for the vulnerable, for the common good. Society understood that individual action is not incidental to large-scale change. It is its foundation. The climate challenge demands the same understanding. Pollution, biodiversity loss, and resource depletion are the cumulative ledger of billions of daily decisions.

Governments can legislate. Scientists can illuminate. But lasting transformation begins when citizens recognise themselves not as passive beneficiaries of nature, but as its custodians. Indian civilisation expressed this with characteristic precision.

The Atharva Veda declares: “The Earth is my mother, and I am her child.” This is not sentiment. It is a framework of obligation. A child cannot take endlessly from a mother while remaining indifferent to her suffering.



From “Use and Throw” to “Use with Responsibility”

Modern consumer culture is engineered for disposability. Buy quickly, use briefly, discard without thought. This habit of mind has shaped not merely markets but our moral relationship with the Earth that sustains us. Environmental educators have long championed three principles: Reduce, Reuse, Recycle. A fourth deserves equal standing today: Refuse. Refuse unnecessary pur-

chases. Refuse excessive packaging. Refuse disposable products when durable alternatives exist. The most sustainable product is the one we never needed to acquire. A household that carries cloth bags, repairs before replacing, and buys with intention rather than habit can prevent thousands of waste items from entering the environment across a lifetime. Simple habits - switching off unused appliances, conserving water, using natural light - are modest individually and transformative collectively. These are not sacrifices. They are the recovery of a relationship with the world that was never meant to be surrendered.

Research conducted across continents finds that time in natural environments reduces stress, restores attention, and builds emotional resilience. A twenty-minute walk among trees can accomplish what hours of scrolling cannot: genuine restoration.

For a generation accustomed to instant response, planting a seed offers a different rhythm. The seed does not respond on demand. It requires patience, care, and trust in time. Watching a sapling grow into a tree teaches responsibility that no motivational slogan can replicate - and quietly strengthens the human relationships formed around it. For a child, the first plant they tend is often the first being beyond the human world that teaches them what it means to care.

Wisdom Encoded in Culture

Long before environmental science existed, Indian communities embedded ecological knowledge into festival and ritual. In Kerala, Vishu marks sea-

sonal cycles through flowering trees. In Telangana, Bathukamma immerses flowers that naturally improve water quality. In Odisha, the Raja festival prescribes rest for the Earth - a symbolic encoding of the practice of following. Across central India, festivals such as Sarhul honour forests that sustain entire ecosystems. These traditions carry an insight that policy has often struggled to grasp: people protect what they celebrate. Conservation succeeds most durably when woven into culture, not appended to it as an annual campaign.

As we get past yet another World Environment Day, the appeal is neither to fear nor to guilt. It is to partnership — between citizen and state, between science and tradition, between the pace of technological progress and the slower, surer rhythms of the living world. We are not spectators of an unfolding catastrophe. The forests that shade us, the rivers that sustain us, the air we breathe are not possessions to be depleted. They are inheritances held in trust, to be passed on in better condition than we received them.

The path forward does not begin at international summits. It begins at home. In our choices. In our neighbourhoods, schools, and communities. There is only one Earth. One shared home. And only one place from which every transformation must begin: “Let me start with myself.

The is Media and communication officer, Press Information Bureau, Government of India

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**5 cops booked for intimidation
in UP after court order**



A case has been registered against five police personnel, including two sub-inspectors, posted at Ballia district's Bairia police station on charges of criminal intimidation and intentional insult, following a court order, officials said on Sunday.

They said the case was registered on Saturday based on a complaint filed by Mahesh Kumar Ojha, a resident of Tiwari-ka-Milki village under Bairia police station area. Ojha said he had lodged a complaint on the IGRS portal regarding the illegal encroachment of a piece of land in the village. Sub-Inspector Pradeep Kumar investigated the matter and filed a report on October 29, 2025, attaching Ojha's photograph without actually contacting him, he claimed.

According to the complaint, when Ojha visited the police station on November 3 last year to complain about the "fabricated" report, the accused police personnel allegedly verbally abused him and threatened to ruin his life by implicating him in a criminal case if he lodged such complaints in the future.

SHO Rajendra Prasad Singh said Ojha had filed a petition in the court, and an FIR was filed on May 24 after an order of the Ballia chief judicial magistrate under Section 175(4) of the BNSS.

In compliance with this order, a case was registered on Saturday against Sub-Inspectors Prabhakar Shukla and Pradeep Kumar, Head Constable Jai Kishun Pal, Constable Dharmendra and Home Guard Ripunjay under Sections 352 (intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of peace) and 351(3) (criminal intimidation) of the BNS, the SHO said, adding that the matter is being investigated. (PTI)

ED approaches court seeking SFIO documents in CMRL money laundering case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

The ED, which is probing a money laundering case linked to CMRL and involving former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan's daughter Veena T, has approached a court here seeking access to documents collected by the SFIO during its investigation into the matter.

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) filed a petition before the Special Court for the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) in Kochi seeking copies of documents gathered by the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO), which had investigated alleged "fake" expenses admitted by Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) before the Income Tax Settlement Commission.

ED sources said the documents sought by the agency include records related to Exalogic Solutions Private Limited, the company owned by Veena, which was



engaged in IT consultancy services. The agency has requested the court to direct the SFIO to provide copies of documents collected during its investigation. The petition is likely to be considered next week.

The ED probe pertains to allegations that CMRL made payments amounting to Rs 2.78 crore to Exalogic Solutions Private Limited



India needs a stronger Lokpal



**PRASHANT
TEWARI**

The Lokpal institution was conceived as a powerful mechanism to combat the menace of corruption in India. Popularly associated with the "Jan Lokpal Bill" movement, it emerged from a strong public demand for greater accountability and transparency in governance. The idea was simple yet transformative: to create an independent statutory body capable of investigating and addressing corruption at the highest levels of public administration. The movement captured the imagination of millions of Indians who had grown weary of pervasive corruption affecting nearly every aspect of public life.

Corruption in India has long been a matter of serious concern. It has often been alleged to exist across political, bureaucratic, financial institutions, public sector units and even judicial spheres. Citizens frequently encounter corruption while dealing with government departments, municipal bodies, and public services. Such practices not only undermine public trust but also weaken democratic institutions and hinder economic and social development. As a result, the establishment of the Lokpal was viewed as a significant step toward restoring confidence in governance and ensuring accountability among public officials.

When the Lokpal Act was eventually enacted, many citizens believed that a new era in the fight against corruption had begun. There was widespread hope that the institution would function independently and effectively, investigating allegations of corruption without fear or favour. However, concerns have been raised by critics regarding the pace and effectiveness of the institution's implementation

and functioning over the years. Some observers argue that successive governments, including the administration led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, have not fully utilized the Lokpal's potential as a central instrument in the battle against corruption.

The expectation among many citizens was that the government would empower the Lokpal and assign it a prominent role in tackling corruption across the country. Such an approach could have reduced the burden on elected representatives and various government investigative departments by creating a specialized body dedicated to investigating corruption-related complaints. An effective and empowered Lokpal could work as a professional institution focused exclusively on ensuring integrity in public life, thereby strengthening governance as a whole.

The fight against corruption remains one of the most important challenges facing India today. As the country continues its journey toward becoming a major global economic and political power, strong institutions are essential to maintaining public confidence and promoting sustainable development. The government of the day, regardless of political affiliation, must demonstrate a clear commitment to transparency, accountability, and ethical governance. Revitalizing and strengthening anti-corruption mechanisms, including the Lokpal, could play an important role in achieving these objectives.

It is also worthwhile to study successful anti-corruption initiatives across the world. Supporters of stronger anti-corruption measures often point to China's extensive anti-graft campaigns as an example of how a determined political leadership can prioritize integrity in public administration. While the political systems of India and China are fundamentally different, the importance of



visible action against corruption in strengthening public confidence remains a lesson worth considering.

Another important aspect of the anti-corruption framework concerns the relationship between the judiciary and oversight institutions. It is often argued that corruption allegations within sections of the judicial system should be addressed through credible and independent mechanisms. Many reform advocates believe that the Lokpal should

the direct jurisdiction of the Lokpal. This approach seeks to balance the need for accountability with the preservation of constitutional principles and institutional independence. Proponents of wider oversight contend that if senior members of the executive namely the prime minister of the country can be subjected to scrutiny, then judges of the High Courts should also be accountable in corruption-related matters through a properly designed institutional framework.

An empowered Lokpal could also help reduce the workload on other institutions. The Supreme Court is already burdened with a large number of cases and constitutional responsibilities. Assigning the specialized task of investigating corruption allegations in lower levels of the judiciary and public administration to an independent anti-corruption body could allow the Court to focus more effectively on its core constitutional functions. Such a division of responsibilities may contribute to greater institutional efficiency and improved governance outcomes.

Public expectations regarding corruption are rising rapidly. In an era of social media, citizens today are more informed, connected, and

vocal than ever before. Through digital platforms, social media, and increased civic awareness, people are demanding higher standards of accountability from those in positions of power including in judiciary. When institutions fail to address corruption effectively, frustration can accumulate and eventually translate into public unrest. Experiences from various countries in the middle east, south east Asia have demonstrated that widespread perceptions of corruption can contribute to political instability and social dissatisfaction.

India's size, diversity, and strategic importance make institutional stability particularly crucial for the world. As one of the world's largest democracies and a key global player, India cannot afford to allow corruption to undermine its developmental ambitions. Strong institutions, transparent governance, and effective accountability mechanisms are essential for maintaining public trust and ensuring long-term national progress.

The fight against corruption should therefore be viewed not merely as a legal or administrative challenge but as a national priority. It requires cooperation among the executive, legislature, judiciary, civil society, media, and

citizens themselves. The Lokpal, if adequately empowered and supported, can serve as a valuable component of this broader effort. Its success depends on political will, institutional independence, adequate resources, and public confidence.

The counter-argument that the Lokpal could create institutional disruption if vested with excessive unilateral powers deserves serious consideration. Accordingly, safeguards should be built into the system. In case of serious misconduct and corruption charges, removal of the Lokpal or its members could be subjected to a rigorous process similar to the impeachment procedure applicable to constitutional authorities. Alternatively, a Constitution Bench comprising senior judges of the Supreme Court could be empowered to examine allegations of misuse of authority by the Lokpal and adjudicate such matters on their merits. Such safeguards would help ensure accountability within the institution itself while preserving its ability to conduct an effective and independent fight against corruption.

In conclusion, the Lokpal represents an important aspiration of the Indian people for clean and accountable governance. While debates may continue regarding its powers, jurisdiction, and effectiveness, there is little disagreement about the need for strong anti-corruption institutions. Strengthening the Lokpal and integrating it effectively into India's governance framework could help restore public faith, improve accountability, and contribute to the creation of a more transparent and just society. The sooner meaningful reforms are undertaken, the better it will be for India's democratic institutions and its more than one billion citizens.

Writer is a public policy expert and columnist

Considerable emphasis on Swadeshi jurisprudence: CJI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that the Supreme Court has consciously approached technology as an aid to human reasoning rather than a substitute for independent judicial thought, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant has said considerable emphasis has been placed on developing "Swadeshi Jurisprudence".

Delivering a lecture at the Oxford Union and the Oxford Law Society on the theme "Constitutional Promise to Digital Reality: Safeguarding Justice in the Age of AI and Technological Advancement," the CJI said in addition to ongoing technological initiatives, serious efforts are underway to explore establishing an indigenous AI ecosystem for the judiciary.

"The Supreme Court of India has consciously approached technology as



an aid to human reasoning rather than as a substitute for independent judicial thought. Considerable emphasis, however, has been placed upon the development of what may be described as a distinctly Indian or 'Swadeshi Jurisprudence': One that remains attentive to our own constitutional values, institutional realities, linguistic diversity, and social conditions rather than relying solely upon imported technological models or assumptions," the CJI said.

He said technology has contributed to something beyond the constitutional promise of access to justice.

"It has, in many ways, brought judicial systems across the world into far closer conversation with one another and strengthened what may now fairly be described as an increasingly interconnected global judicial community," he said.

Young lawyers, judicial officers and legal professionals are an encouraging source for the judiciary's technological transformation, the CJI said.

Allahabad HC rejects bail plea of Tauqueer Raza Khan in Bareilly violence case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has dismissed the bail plea of Tauqueer Raza, the alleged mastermind of the Bareilly violence case, observing there is a significant risk that he may once again incite a particular community and disturb harmony.

Justice Arun Kumar Singh Deshwal passed the order on June 5 rejecting the bail application filed by Khan.

"Considering the entire facts and circumstances of the case and upon perusal of records, it is not in dispute that the applicant persuaded several youth of the Muslim community in a public meeting to assemble at the Islamia Inter College.

"Despite the invocation of Section 163 BNSS 2023, while proceeding towards the Islamia Inter College, they were stopped by the police;



then they became involved in arson and started pelting stones, throwing petrol bombs and destroying the public property, including causing injuries to several police personnel," the court said. It said that the statement of the eyewitness and the video clip show that Khan was the main person who persuaded these people through provocative speech to assemble at the Islamia Inter College. "Therefore, for the offence committed by the

crowd, the applicant will also be liable being the main conspirator for the offences," it said. "Considering the applicant's extensive criminal history in similar cases, there is a significant risk that, if released, he may once again incite a particular community and disturb peace and harmony. Therefore, this Court is not inclined to grant bail to the applicant," it said.

According to the police, on September 26, Khan gave a call to members of a particular community to assemble at the Islamiya Inter College in Bareilly.

Despite prohibitory orders in force, a crowd of about 200-250 people gathered and proceeded towards Shyamganj Chauraha from the Maulana Azad Inter College. The crowd, holding boards and raising provocative slogans, paid little heed to the warning and persuasions made by the police personnel at the spot.

Treat ex-IAS Khemka as empanelled additional secretary, secretary: HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The Punjab and Haryana High Court has held that retired IAS officer Ashok Khemka be treated as an empanelled additional secretary and secretary for future assignments.

The verdict came on the Haryana-cadre, 1991-batch officer's plea, contending that he was not empanelled as additional secretary or secretary to the government of India on the grounds that the requirement of having worked on central deputation for a minimum period of three years at the level of deputy secretary and above, is not fulfilled.

However, several IAS officers, who had 'nil' experience on deputation in the rank of deputy secretary and above with the government of India, were empanelled at the rank of additional secretary by granting them relaxation, he argued. Khemka



had challenged three orders passed by the Central Administrative Tribunal in July 2023, whereby his claim that he should be treated as having been empanelled at the level of additional secretary/secretary to the government of India prior to the date of his retirement, was rejected. Khemka, known for his uprightness during his nearly 34-year career which saw 57 postings, superannuated on April 30, 2025.

He grabbed headlines in 2012 when he cancelled the mutation of a Gurugram land deal linked to Congress leader Sonia Gandhi's son-in-law Robert Vadra. A mutation is part of the process to transfer ownership of a piece of land.

Allowing Khemka's plea, the bench of justices Harsimran Singh Sethi and Deepak Manchanda held that the benefit of parity has to be granted to the petitioner

with the other similarly situated officers so that no prejudice is caused to him.

The court stated that the only question which arises for consideration is whether, the benefit of empanelment with the central government in the rank of additional secretary/secretary can be granted to the petitioner despite an eligibility clause that such benefit can only be granted to an IAS officer, who served on deputation with the government in the rank of deputy secretary or above for a minimum of three years.

"Though, the rules prescribed such eligibility qualification but, the grant of the relaxation of such rule can also be exercised by the Union of India while extending the said benefit to an otherwise eligible officer. The said relaxation has already been exercised by the Union of India a number of times to the similarly situated IAS officers," read the court order

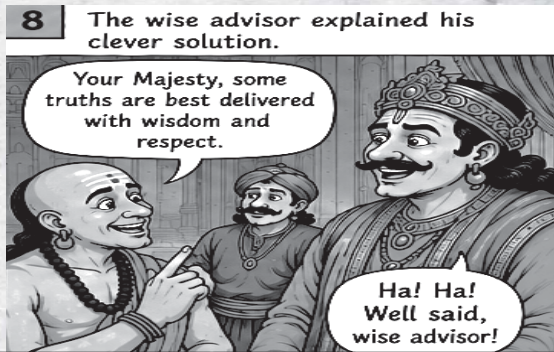
dated May 29.

Once, similarly situated officers as that of the petitioner were granted relaxation for empanelling them as additional secretary/secretary, the question that why such relaxation was not granted to the petitioner without any valid reason remains uncontroverted, the court observed.

It further said once, the Centre exercises jurisdiction to relax the requirement of having worked on central deputation for a minimum period of three years at the level of deputy secretary and above and such relaxation was even exercised in favour of similarly situated IAS officers, the non-exercise of the same will surely amount to discrimination, unless and until any differentiating fact is brought to the notice of the Court which exist between the petitioner herein and the other officers, who have been granted relaxation while empanelling.

Still Mind, Calm Water

Wisdom of Careful Words



MORAL OF THE STORY: Speak the truth with wisdom and kindness

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Voting ends in Gilgit-Baltistan

Voting concluded on Sunday in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir's Gilgit-Baltistan region for elections to its so-called legislative assembly, with counting underway. Officials said polling took place between 8 am and 5 pm. It was peaceful, and no incident of major violence was reported. India has lodged a strong protest with Pakistan over the elections, maintaining that Gilgit-Baltistan is part of Indian territory that has been "illegally and forcibly" occupied by Pakistan. Reiterating its position, India has said the entire Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, including Gilgit-Baltistan, are integral and inalienable parts of India by virtue of the "complete, legal and irrevocable accession" of Jammu and Kashmir to India in 1947. According to a list issued by the authorities, 1,391 polling stations were set up across the Gilgit-Baltistan region, of which 551 were categorised as highly sensitive. (PTI)

BANGLADESH

Ties with Turkiye get a boost

Bangladesh and Turkiye have reached an understanding to form a joint ministerial level committee on defence and foreign affairs to strengthen bilateral political cooperation. The decision was announced on Saturday after a meeting between Prime Minister Tarique Rahman and Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan, who arrived in Dhaka on a three-day visit. "Bangladesh and Turkiye have decided to form a joint committee at the ministerial level on defence and foreign affairs to strengthen bilateral relations," the state-run BSS news agency reported quoting the prime minister's press wing. The meeting decided to hold annual foreign office consultations between foreign and defence ministers of the two countries to further deepen the "strategic relations," the press wing spokesman said. (PTI)

US sees nuclear renaissance with new micro-reactor, eyes global markets, including India

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

A small nuclear reactor developed by a private US company has achieved first criticality, a stepping stone in the development of small modular reactors which Washington plans to sell to countries including India. The Mark-0 demonstration reactor, built by Antares Nuclear, achieved first criticality — the start of a self-sustaining nuclear chain reaction — on June 4, a month ahead of schedule as US President Donald Trump encouraged the private sector to develop newer nuclear reactors. Experts describe the

Palestinians suffer from lack of proper toilets across Gaza's vast tent cities

WAFAA SHURAF/A/
TOQA EZZIDIN ■ Khan Younis

In their bare-bones tent in southern Gaza, Mostafa Shaaban built his family's makeshift toilet behind a curtain in a corner. He dug a shallow pit in the sandy soil, poured a concrete slab around it, fixed a bottomless bucket over the hole, then topped it off with a battered, plastic toilet seat. It reeks with a foul odour and buzzes with flies and mosquitoes only a few feet from where they sleep and prepare meals. Every week, Shaaban has to dig the sewage sludge out of the pit. But at least it's more private than the fetid communal latrines used by hundreds of other people in their sprawling tent camp. "I did not want the kids and my

Arab attacker opens fire in central Israel, killing 1 and wounding 5

MELANIE LIDMAN
■ Tel Aviv

A Palestinian man with Israeli citizenship went on a shooting rampage in several towns in central Israel on Sunday, killing one person and wounding five others, according to Israeli police. The attacker was killed by the police. The number of places where people were shot initially raised concerns that there could be multiple, coordinated attackers who had crossed over from the West Bank - evoking memories of the Hamas-led attacks in October 2023 - before police eventually determined that it was a lone gunman and an accomplice. Rescue services Magen David Adom said that it received the first reports of a



Israeli security forces are deployed at the scene of a shooting attack carried out by a Palestinian citizen of Israel near Tzur Yitzhak in central Israel PTI

shooting at a gas station near the town of Kokhav Yair, located on the Israeli side of the boundary with the West Bank, at around 10:30 am Several other shooting reports were received soon afterwards, in the towns of Tsur Natan, Tsur Yitzhak, and close to the Israeli settlement of Sal'it, located inside the West Bank. Police arrested a second person involved in the attack

later Sunday. The man attempted to stab police with a glass bottle during the arrest, but there were no injuries, police said. Additional investigations were ongoing. Israel's Channel 12 reported that the attacker stayed in his car while shooting, allowing him to reach several locations within a matter of minutes.

Pakistan's interior minister reaches Tehran as tensions rises over Strait of Hormuz

SAMY MAGDY/KAREEM
CHEHAYEB/MELANIE LIDMAN
■ Cairo

Pakistan's interior minister was in Tehran on Sunday in a fresh bid to restart negotiations between Iran and the US, as the American military said it shot down two more Iranian drones over the Strait of Hormuz that threatened international maritime traffic. The latest action came as the US administration presses Iran to make a deal to end the

war in the Middle East, which has strained the global economy and threatened a hunger crisis in some of the world's most vulnerable countries. The heaviest fighting ended with a preliminary ceasefire on April 8, but the sides have not been able to agree on a long-term end to the war. Fighting between Israel and the Lebanese militant group Hezbollah continued, meanwhile, despite last week's announcement that a



US-brokered ceasefire had been extended. Pakistani Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi is in Tehran to deliver a message to Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei from Pakistan's army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir, according to Iranian state-run IRNA news agency. Khamenei has not been seen in public since he was named the Islamic Republic's ruler after his father was killed on the first day of the

war on February 28 when the US and Israel launched a bombardment campaign against Iran. Naqvi met with Iranian Interior Minister Eskandar Momeni late Saturday, and held talks Sunday morning with Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, according to official Iranian media. There were no details on the contents of the message. Pakistani authorities have said Islamabad, with support from regional countries including

Qatar, Turkey and Egypt, has been working to help bridge differences between the United States and Iran and encourage efforts aimed at reducing tensions and ensuring the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz. Fire continues between Israel and Hezbollah. Meanwhile, the new ceasefire in Lebanon, which was announced during US-brokered talks between Israel and Lebanon in Washington last week, did not appear to be holding. (AP)

US: 12 wounded in shooting, police search for suspects

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Toledo (Ohio)

A shooting near a community festival in Toledo, Ohio, wounded at least 12 people, and police said a search for the suspects was ongoing following an outbreak of gunfire that sent crowds scrambling for cover. Two of the injured were in a critical condition, Toledo Deputy Police Chief Joe Heffernan said. He said it appeared there were at least two people firing weapons who were "probably shooting at each other." The Toledo Police Department said the shooting happened near the Old West End Festival, an annual gathering of live music and home tours in a historic district of



the city. The department said an active search was underway for those responsible. "I am deeply concerned about the situation in Toledo tonight. Summer festivals should be safe spaces for families to spend time together without fear of violence," Ohio Gov. Mike DeWine said in a statement.

Israel strikes Beirut's southern suburbs days after ceasefire

KAREEM CHEHAYEB/SAMY MAGDY/
MELANIE LIDMAN ■ Beirut

Israel struck the southern Beirut suburbs on Sunday, just days after a ceasefire agreement in Washington went into effect. A statement from Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's office said the strikes were in retaliation for the Hezbollah militant group firing toward northern Israel earlier, and that the attacks targeted "command centres" in the sprawling urban neighbourhoods. Hezbollah did not immediately claim responsibility for firing at Israel. The strikes come after the Lebanese and Israeli governments in Washington renewed a ceasefire agreement in ongoing talks that Beirut hopes will bring an end to the war across the country. There was no immediate word of casualties. Israel had already struck the southern suburbs of the Lebanese capital twice since the first agreement between Lebanon and Israel went into effect on April 17. Strikes over



southern Lebanon continue daily, meanwhile, and Hezbollah fighters and Israeli troops have also clashed. Israel announced on Monday that it would strike the southern suburbs after Hezbollah claimed attacks in northern Israel, but last-gasp talks via Washington halted the attacks, on the condition that Hezbollah stop targeting Israel's border towns. Iran had warned that an attack on the Lebanese capital would trigger

renewed full-scale war across the Mideast, amid ongoing efforts by Pakistan to restart talks between Tehran and Washington. The Iranian-backed Hezbollah has rejected the US-brokered deal and instead endorsed Iran's demand that ending the war in Lebanon be part of the negotiations with the US. The fighting in Lebanon, where Israeli forces have seized large swaths of the south in its latest

ground invasion, threatens efforts to end the Iran war and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a key transit point for oil and gas. Its closure has jolted the world economy. Iran has demanded that any lasting truce extend to Lebanon. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who faces elections later this year, wants to press ahead with Israel's offensive until he considers that Hezbollah no longer poses a threat. Lebanon's army commander, Gen. Rodolphe Haikal, headed to Pakistan Saturday at the invitation of Pakistan's army chief. The Lebanese army gave no further details and did not say whether it is related to Pakistan's mediation between Iran and the US. Meanwhile, Pakistan's interior minister was in Tehran on Sunday in a fresh bid to restart negotiations between Iran and the US, as the American military said it shot down two more Iranian drones over the Strait of Hormuz that threatened international maritime traffic. (AP)



Current energy shock should add more urgency for developing SAF, other renewables: IATA chief

MANOJ RAMMOHAN
■ Rio de Janeiro

The current energy shock should add even more urgency to the development of renewables, including SAF, and the sustainable aviation fuel production is projected to touch around 2.4 million tonnes this year, accounting for just 0.8 per cent of the global jet fuel use, according to airlines' grouping IATA. Jet fuel prices have soared in recent times due to the West Asia crisis, and the operational costs of airlines have gone up. To increase SAF (sustainable aviation fuel) production, the International Air Transport Association (IATA), which represents around 370 airlines worldwide, has suggested expanding renewable energy supply, strengthening policy support, ensuring open access to fuel infrastructure and other measures.

"The current energy shock should add even more urgency to the development of renewables, including SAF. "But we have yet to see either the energy shock, the need to develop energy independence and jobs, or the urgency to mitigate climate change materialise in the incentives needed to create a viable SAF market," IATA Director General Willie Walsh said in a release. Preeti Jain, Head of Net Zero Research and Programs at IATA, said the SAF production is projected at 2.4 million tonnes, while the production capacity is projected at nearly 9 million tonnes. The capacity is being underutilised due to the current framework of policies, which is structured in such a way that it favours production for renewable diesel, she said at a briefing on Saturday on the sidelines of the IATA AGM here. (PTI)



development in the US have the capacity to generate power in the range of a few hundred kilowatts to 1.2 megawatts (MW). These reactors could be assembled and

flown in an aircraft for deployment anywhere in the world. The US is also planning to use nuclear power for future space missions. The Antares reactor is the

first among the three small reactors to demonstrate new nuclear capabilities in the US by July 4, the 250th anniversary of American Independence. The other two micro-reactors are -eVinci developed by Westinghouse, and Kaleidos by Radiant. "I think June 4th will be a historic day in the American nuclear renaissance," Energy Secretary Chris Wright said here. Last year, Trump signed executive orders to remove regulatory barriers in the development of new nuclear technologies. The orders granted the Department of Energy authority to approve advanced reactor designs

and projects, which was previously the job of the Nuclear Regulatory Commission, the regulator of the nuclear industry in the US. Korsnick said the development of fracking technologies a few decades ago made gas the preferred choice for power generation, leading to stagnation in the nuclear sector. "If you look back over the last 30-plus years, the demand in the United States has been relatively flat. Fracking really became much more prevalent and dropped the price of natural gas pretty significantly, making it the preferential source and a selection to be made," she said. (PTT)

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Ola Consumer turns profitable as rivals burn ₹100 cr per month

Ola Consumer has turned free cash-flow positive and achieved profitability, widening the gap with rivals that continue to spend heavily to gain market share in India's fiercely competitive ride-hailing sector, according to company disclosures, industry estimates and people familiar with the matter. The company reported operating revenue of about ₹1,171 crore in FY25, ahead of Rapido's ₹934 crore. Industry estimates suggest the gap is even wider on a net revenue basis – after accounting for customer discounts and driver incentives – with Ola estimated to have generated ₹250-300 crore in net revenue during the latest quarter, compared with around ₹40-45 crore for Rapido and ₹35-40 crore for Uber, according to people familiar with the developments.

The performance reflects Ola's shift over the past two years towards a profitability-focused strategy, prioritising monetisation and cost efficiencies over aggressive discount-led growth. "Short-term growth driven by discounts and incentives is difficult to sustain. Revenue quality and the ability to retain value from each transaction are more meaningful indicators of business strength," a person familiar with the matter said. Industry executives and investors estimate Rapido is currently spending ₹80-100 crore a month to support growth and expand market share. Uber's India ride-hailing business is also estimated to be losing more than ₹100 crore a month. Regulatory filings showed Uber India's ride-hailing unit reported revenue of about ₹88 crore in FY25 while posting a segment loss of approximately ₹1,401 crore.

India's energy demand surge to shift global markets: Rosneft chief

India will account for about half of global oil demand growth and 15 per cent of the increase in global electricity consumption over the next decade, making it one of the world's most important energy markets, Igor Sechin, chief executive of Russian oil producer Rosneft, said. Speaking at the St Petersburg International Economic Forum, Sechin said India's oil consumption is expected to rise 44 per cent to nearly 8 million barrels per day by 2035, while electricity demand is projected to surge 80 per cent to almost 3,000 terawatt-hours, approaching the current consumption levels in the European Union.

"Speaking of our strategic partners, I would like to specifically mention India. Today, India's economy is one of the key drivers of global energy consumption growth," he said. According to the International Energy Agency's projections, over the next 10 years, India will account for about 15 per cent of the global increase in electricity demand. India also holds a unique position in the oil market - over the next 10 years, the country will account for approximately half of global oil demand growth. However, he warned that the conflict around the Strait of Hormuz and broader geopolitical tensions pose risks to India's energy security, given the country's growing dependence on imported energy and its role as a key driver of global demand growth.

"The conflict in the Strait of Hormuz, along with new risks, will unfortunately have a negative impact on meeting the needs of the Indian economy," he said. Sechin said disruptions in Hormuz extend beyond oil and gas markets, affecting fertilizer shipments and raising the risk of higher food prices, with India, Africa and Southeast Asia among the most vulnerable regions. Fertilizer prices have already risen sharply this year, he said.

Developments in West Asia, oil prices, FII trading activity key factors for market movement: Analysts

The stock market this week will track simmering tensions in West Asia, its impact on crude oil prices, and trading activity of foreign investors, analysts said.

The trading week may begin on a cautious note following a sharp decline in the US markets over the weekend, an expert said.

Besides, the progress of the monsoon and the inflation data announcement will also be important factors to watch out for.

"This week will be driven by key inflation and global macroeconomic data releases. In India, investors will closely track inflation data for May, scheduled for release on June 12, along with foreign exchange reserves data on the same day.

"Globally, developments around the US-Iran negotiations and their implications for crude oil prices, currency movements, and overall risk sentiment will remain in focus," Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

US markets ended sharply lower on Friday, with the Nasdaq Composite tumbling 4.18 per cent.

The S&P 500 dived 2.64 per cent and the Dow Jones

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | MONDAY | JUNE 8, 2026

Tata Motors to keep investing in EV, hydrogen CV tech: Chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Tata Motors will keep on investing in electric and hydrogen-based technologies for commercial vehicles, Chairman N Chandrasekaran said, emphasising that the transition to cleaner mobility requires a portfolio of electric, hydrogen and cleaner internal combustion engine (ICE) technologies.

In his address to shareholders in the company's annual report for 2025-26, the chairman noted that advances in digital technologies and AI are transforming how mobility products are designed, experienced and supported.

Chandrasekaran, who is also the chairman of Tata Sons, observed that the transition to clean energy, heightened expectations on safety and

reconfiguration of global supply chains are redefining competitiveness.

Geopolitical and uneven economic recovery are adding further complexity, making agility and resilience critical capabilities, he added.

"The transition to cleaner mobility requires a portfolio of electric, hydrogen and cleaner ICE technologies. While we

scale the portfolio of zero-emission electric CVs, we will continue to invest in hydrogen-based technologies for heavier-duty segments," he stated.

The Tata Motors chairman expressed confidence that the company is well-positioned to sustain its profitable growth journey, supported by a strong balance sheet, improving

returns and focus on resilience.

"Our focus will remain on delivering industry-leading growth, profitability and returns, supported by a disciplined capital allocation to address emerging mobility trends," Chandrasekaran said.

According to him, the trends include digital-led solutions, connected vehicle technologies, advanced driver assistance systems, data-driven fleet services and new-age powertrains — capabilities that will shape the future of safe, efficient and intelligent commercial mobility.

"During the year (2025-26), your company recorded its highest ever revenues of ₹83,855 crore, compared to ₹76,359 crore in FY25, delivering a robust year-on-year growth of 9.8 per cent," Chandrasekaran said in the letter.

Reliance Infra hit by share trading curb, seeks review of insolvency-linked surveillance framework

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Reliance Infrastructure Limited on Sunday said that it has sought a review of the insolvency-related surveillance framework, under which trading in the company's stock is allowed only once a week.

Reliance Infrastructure Limited, in a statement, said it has submitted a formal representation to the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), National Stock Exchange (NSE), and Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE), seeking a review of the Additional Surveillance Measure (ASM) linked to Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) and the related trading restrictions on its shares.

Citing adverse impact on more than 7 lakh public shareholders, Reliance Infra said that the current framework, which permits trading only once a week within a narrow ±5 per cent price

band, results in price movements that are largely mechanical and predictable. It emphasised the need to ensure that market mechanisms continue to facilitate fair price discovery and maintain investor confidence.

"The company believes that such restrictions may not adequately reflect prevailing business fundamentals,

operational performance or long-term value creation potential," it said.

According to the statement, Reliance Infrastructure shares are otherwise actively and widely traded in the market, reflecting sustained investor participation and liquidity.

The company said the continuation of such anomalous and artificial trading restrictions is counterproductive to the interests of 7 lakh retail and small public shareholders and undermines the efficient functioning of the market.

The company further submitted that the impact of these restrictions falls disproportionately on its public shareholders.

"During lower-circuit phases, shareholders are often unable to exit their investments at a reasonable market price, while the value of their holdings erodes by a near-fixed percentage each week," the statement said.

NCLAT quashes Ligare Aviation's insolvency; loan from Religare Enterprises round-tripping

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has set aside insolvency proceedings against Ligare Aviation Ltd, holding that the NCLT erred in admitting the plea filed by Religare Enterprises without properly examining the nature of the underlying transactions, which was "only round tripping of money" and not "any genuine financial transaction".

In a strongly worded order, the appellate tribunal said the material on record "clearly proves" that there was no financial debt disbursed by the financial creditor (Religare Enterprises) to the corporate debtor (Ligare Aviation) for consideration of the time value of money, a key requirement under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).

Allowing appeals filed by Daiichi Sankyo Company, a Japanese global pharmaceutical company and a shareholder, NCLAT observed that the transactions in question were merely a "round tripping of money/layering of money" under-

taken for "some undisclosed fraudulent purposes" and did not create any financial debt capable of triggering insolvency proceedings.

"We have come to the conclusion that the materials on the record clearly proves that there was no

financial debt which was disbursed by Financial Creditor (Religare Finvest) to the Corporate Debtor (Ligare Aviation) for time value of money..." said a two-member NCLAT bench.

Moreover, the MoU for loan was a "sham one-paper document created dishonestly to give the colour of genuine transactions to fraudulent transaction," NCLAT noted its order passed on May 27, 2026.

Religare Enterprises and Ligare Aviation are both group companies and related parties. A host of companies, including these two, were controlled by Malvinder Mohan Singh and Shivinder Mohan Singh, the two brothers who were ex-promoters of Ranbaxy Laboratories and Fortis Healthcare.

In its 69-page-long order, the

NCLAT also faulted the New Delhi-based Principal Bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) for admitting the insolvency plea filed by Religare Enterprises despite the absence of a genuine financial debt.

"Adjudicating Authority (NCLT) has not even looked into the plea that the amount was immediately transferred and did not remain even for 24 hours with the corporate debtor," said NCLAT.

The NCLAT noted that ₹3.6 crore transferred by Religare Arts Investment Management Ltd (RAIML) to Ligare Aviation on March 31, 2009 was remitted to Religare Finvest, a subsidiary company of Religare Enterprises, which was reflected in the bank transfer of the same day.

FPIs pull out ₹43,000 crore in first week of June

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Foreign investors continued to pare their exposure to Indian equities, pulling out nearly ₹43,000 crore in the first week of June amid a shift of global capital towards technology and artificial intelligence (AI)-linked opportunities overseas and persistent weakness in the rupee.

With this, total outflows by Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) from Indian equities have reached ₹2.67 lakh crore so far in 2026, surpassing the ₹1.66 lakh crore withdrawn

during the whole of 2025, according to data available with the National Securities Depository Ltd (NSDL).

Market experts said FPIs have been reducing their exposure to Indian equities due to a combination of weak earnings growth, rupee depreciation and the emergence of more attractive investment opportunities in global markets, particularly in the technology and AI space.

"Apart from higher US yields and dollar strength, global investors are also real-locating capital towards some of the largest technol-

ogy and AI-related public market opportunities currently emerging globally. The upcoming SpaceX IPO, along with anticipated capital market activity around leading AI companies, is attracting significant global liquidity, leading to temporary capital rotation away from emerging markets, including India," Alpha AMC Founder Rajesh Singla said.

According to the data, FPIs were net sellers in all months of 2026 except February. They pulled out ₹35,962 crore in January before turning net buyers in February, when they invested ₹22,615 crore,

the highest monthly inflow in 17 months.

However, the trend reversed sharply in March,

when foreign investors drew a record ₹1.17 lakh crore. The selling continued in April with net outflows of

₹60,847 crore and in May with withdrawals of ₹32,963 crore. The exodus persisted in June, with FPIs pulling out ₹42,927 crore during the first week of the month.

Market experts said that persistent depreciation of the rupee has emerged as another key factor behind the sustained outflows.

The Indian currency has weakened nearly 6 per cent so far in 2026 and around 10 per cent over the past year, falling from the mid-80s to about 95.5 against the US dollar despite efforts by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to stabilise the currency.

LIC in talks with regulators for long-term instruments to match liabilities: CEO

KUMAR DIPANKAR
■ New Delhi

State-owned Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) is engaging with key financial regulators, including the Reserve Bank and Sebi, to expand the availability of long-term investment instruments as inflows into its annuity products keep on rising, CEO and MD R Doraiswamy said.

An Annuity product converts an accumulated retirement corpus into a guaranteed, lifelong stream of income. When one invests a lump sum, LIC pays a regular pension for life, ensuring the savings aren't outlived.

"When the annuity markets are becoming more favoured by the policyholders, and more investments flow into annuities, we need to necessarily have long-term investments matching that kind of long-term liabilities. So we have been in touch with the (insurance) regulator as well as the regulators like SEBI, as well as RBI and the requirements of LIC, particularly are being duly communicated to them," he told PTI in an interview.

He further said the sector regulator, Insurance

Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), has also been taking proactive steps in ensuring that the evolving needs of the market are also fully met by the insurance company.

"Given the fact that insurance companies generate long-term funds, they go on to meet the long-term financing requirements in terms of infrastructure needs and nation-building. The regulations are also getting aligned with the requirements. So it is a win-win situation for both of us. We keep working together," he said.

LIC has a substantial portfolio of annuity business, which is very long-tailed with liabilities running into 30, 40, 50 years. So the investment of funds is based on the underlying business and the underlying fund.

Asked if LIC could sustain a high net Value of New Business (VNB) margin of over 20 per cent in FY27 as well, Doraiswamy said, the effort that the Corporation is taking is to see that the VNB margin, or more than that, the gross VNB, as well as the performance in almost all parameters, keep improving.

PROSPECT



Assam Governor Lakshman Prasad Acharya hosted Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma, along with the Members of the State Council of Ministers over an interaction 'Sneha Milan' at Lok Bhavan, Guwahati



As directed by CM Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma, Minister Jayanta Mallabaruah visited Shri Shri Kamakhya Dham and held discussions with the Doloi community, local residents and senior officials regarding the proposed Kamakhya Corridor



MLA and Advisor to CM Nagaland Daochier Imchen called on Nagaland BJP President Benjamin Yephthomi at his residence.

Book on Gita, Gurbani-led wellness launched in Delhi

Senior RSS functionary Indresh Kumar has asserted that “not harming anyone is the greatest health”. He was speaking at the launch of Nirogta Ke Sutra, a book on healthy, balanced living rooted in Gurbani and the Bhagavad Gita. “Not harming anyone is the greatest health,” Kumar said. “To harm others, one harbours jealousy and anger, which sicken body and mind.” He urged living life as a mission and stressed healthy thoughts for a healthy society. The book, by RSS volunteer Dr Sham Lal Kathpalia, was released in the presence of Union MoS and Delhi BJP chief Harsh Malhotra, Dadhichi Deh Daan Samiti founder Alok Kumar, spiritual guru Baba Bhupinder Singh Patiala, and educationist Dr Ved Tandon. Malhotra lauded Kathpalia’s efforts. Speakers dubbed Kathpalia’s life an example of Indian culture, service, and spirituality. Dr Tandon said true health begins by looking within. The event concluded with children reciting the Gita’s 15th chapter Purushottam Yoga in Sanskrit.

Team Europe delegation to visit Assam on June 8

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

A high-level “Team Europe” delegation of the European Union (EU) will be in Guwahati, Assam, on 8-9 June to advance collaboration opportunities between Europe and India’s North-Eastern States (Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Sikkim, and Tripura), in line with the priorities set out in the joint Comprehensive Strategic Agenda agreed between the EU and India at their summit last January.

The visit will focus on value chains across sectors where Europe and the State of Assam and the region as a whole share strong synergies, including renewable and green energy, sustainable urban infrastructure, healthcare and pharmaceuticals, semiconductors and electronics manufacturing, tea and agri-food processing, flavours and fragrances, and AYUSH.

The EU delegation will comprise ambassadors and senior representatives from EU Member States, including Hervé Delphin, Ambassador of the European Union to India and Bhutan, alongside European business representatives.

During the visit, the Team Europe Ambassadors will



engage in a bilateral meeting with Assam’s Chief Minister, Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma, while a business delegation led by the Federation of European Businesses in India (FEBI) will also hold discussions with State officials to identify trade and investment opportunities. The delegation will participate in the “Blue Valleys: Building ecosystems and value chains between India and Europe” workshop on 9th June, organised by the Government of Assam, which will bring together European and Indian businesses to explore partnerships in sustainable value chains, industries and innovation.

The visit will also see the launch of Assam’s first Blue Valley Cluster, a new industrial hub focused on fragrances, flavours, AYUSH, and food processing. This 4P (public-private-people-partnership) cluster will seek to connect Europe, North-East India, and

Bhutan, promoting innovation, research, sustainable manufacturing, and business collaborations. This pilot project, led by the Assam government, is aligned with the Blue Valleys initiative, which was introduced at the 2026 EU-India Summit.

The Blue Valley aims to promote industrial clusters, MSME linkages, and sector-specific value chain integration between the EU and India while ensuring economic growth and environmental sustainability. Key sectors identified under this initiative include clean energy, natural ingredients, bamboo-based industries, eco-friendly textiles, biotech, wellness, and smart manufacturing.

By combining funding, skills development, and sustainability standards, the initiative seeks to create scalable business models that benefit local communities and connect them to European markets.

Tata Steel UK project faces delay due to grid issues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Tata Steel may have to defer the timeline of its 1.25-billion-pound UK project for transitioning to a low-carbon steel-making process by six to eight months, as the company is facing delays in “securing access to electricity”.

As part of its decarbonisation plan, Tata Steel is setting up the UK’s largest low-carbon EAF (electric arc furnace) project of 3.2 million tonnes capacity at Port Talbot with 1.25 billion pounds of investment to replace its now-shut blast furnace plant of similar capacity.

Before experiencing delays in securing power access, the company was looking to begin operations of the EAF project by late 2027 or early 2028.

“While we are working with ESO (Electricity System Operator) and National Grid for the new electrical infrastructure, National Grid has formally alerted to us that their connectivity project is delayed,” said Koushik Chatterjee, Executive Director (ED) & Chief Financial Officer (CFO) at Tata Steel.

The National Grid has informed about some potential delays versus the



original planned date of the high voltage connection, he said, adding that the company is working with all the stakeholders, including the UK government, to mitigate the impact and develop revised schedules. The official noted that major demolition works at the site have been completed, and fabrication and delivery of equipment are continuing at a pace. Securing access to higher-power electricity is critical for the planned transition.

The project — being built up with 500 million pounds of government support — aims to reduce site-level CO2 emissions by 90 per cent — equivalent to 5 million tonnes annually.

Meanwhile, on Wednesday (June 3), the project site at Port Talbot witnessed a fire incident. However, all personnel were accounted for and evacuated from the area safely, Tata Steel UK said on Thursday.

Chatterjee further said that his company is working with National Grid and the UK government to resolve the issues.

“We are working with the UK government, the National Grid and (Electricity System Operator (ESO), which is the electricity supplier, to see if we can mitigate it, but somewhere between six months to eight months will certainly be there, maybe higher, after we have built the plant,” Chatterjee said, responding to a question on whether the company is seeing any delays in commissioning the project.

The official said Tata Steel is working out if the duration of the delay can be reduced, but ruled out any possibility of avoiding the situation. “We are actively working to see if we can reduce it (the delay) further, but there will be some imminent delays,” the ED & CFO said without sharing further details.

Spear Corps conducts exercise Sarv Suraksha

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Spear Corps successfully conducted Joint Exercise Sarv Suraksha 2026, a three-day Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR) exercise from June 4 to June 6, 2026, at Rangapahar Military Station (RMS). The exercise brought together troops of Spear Corps, personnel of 12 Battalion NDRF, SDRF and representatives of key civil and military agencies engaged in disaster management across the region.

Conceived to enhance multi-agency synergy, validate SOPs (Standard Operating Procedures) and strengthen operational readiness, the exercise focused on flood relief and



disaster response contingencies across the Spear Corps Area of Responsibility encompassing Nagaland, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur & Tripura.

Participants underwent intensive training through lectures, case studies and

showcased the employment of cutting-edge technologies and modern disaster response equipment, highlighting their growing role in enabling swift and effective humanitarian assistance operations.

Some key highlights were the rapid construction of a medium girder bridge in a simulated disaster-affected area, drone-assisted rescue, etc., demonstrating the engineering capability and swift response mechanism of Spear Corps in restoring critical connectivity.

The exercise significantly enhanced inter-operability, communication and mutual understanding among participating agencies, reinforcing a coordinated and resilient framework for the North East.

Packaging firms remain upbeat on FY27 growth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India’s leading packaging solution providers are navigating rising raw material costs, supply chain disruptions, and export uncertainties stemming from the ongoing geopolitical tensions in West Asia, but remain optimistic about stronger growth prospects in FY27 driven by domestic consumption, capacity expansion and improving product mix.

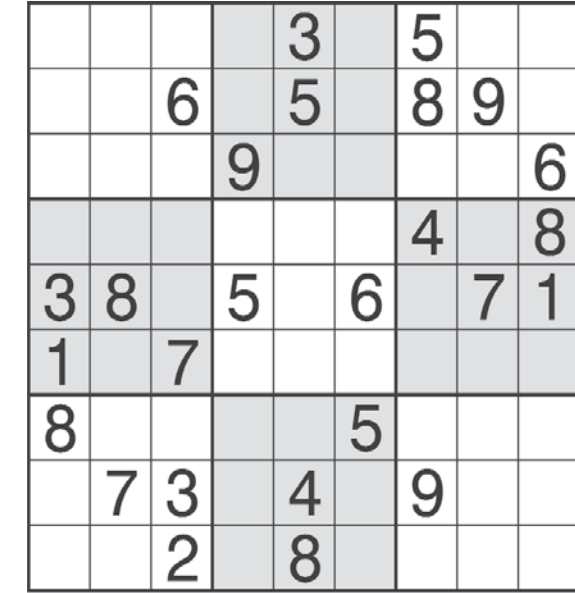
Executives from major listed packaging companies in their latest quarter earnings said the crisis in West Asia has disrupted the availability of key petrochemi-

cal-based inputs and increased logistics costs, creating near-term challenges for the industry that serves sectors such as FMCG, personal care, pharmaceuticals, and food products.

“The crisis has affected both availability and cost of our key raw materials,” said EPL Ltd Managing Director and Global CEO Hemant Bakshi.

The tube-packaging company, formerly known as Essel Propack, is “proactively navigating” the situation with a clear and structured approach, he said, adding that EPL is prioritising supply security for customers while ensuring that higher input costs are passed through.

DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

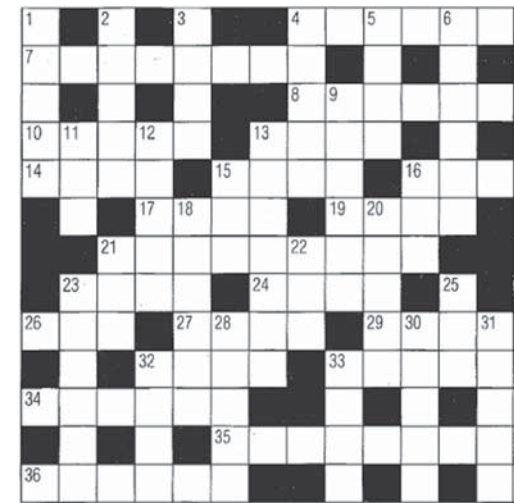
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (6.6.26)								
6	1	4	8	7	5	9	3	2
5	3	7	4	2	9	8	1	6
2	8	9	1	6	3	4	7	5
8	2	3	5	4	1	6	9	7
9	7	6	3	8	2	5	4	1
4	5	1	6	9	7	2	8	3
7	4	5	2	3	8	1	6	9
3	6	2	9	1	4	7	5	8
1	9	8	7	5	6	3	2	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
MONDAY | JUNE 8, 2026



- ACROSS**
- 4 No longer forward, nevertheless advanced (6)
- 7 One holding the record for a flight (5,3)
- 8 Part of the anatomy of a girl of ten (6)
- 10 Golf club shortly out of money (5)
- 13 They amuse most of the boys at the end of the street (4)
- 14 Its riders are on board (4)
- 15 Has to go round the corner, being a painter (4)
- 16 Heart sickening knowledge? (3)
- 17 Miss the wild part of California (4)
- 19 Little excitement for teacher around Tuesday (4)

- DOWN**
- 1 Hellish place in old Ethiopia (5)
- 2 Distinguished house or Roman ruin (5)
- 3 Personal cover (4)
- 4 Praise one's former spouse, maybe a lot (5)
- 5 They're all in favour (4)
- 6 The book on the lectern? (6)
- 9 Plant you'll find some days in a new shop (6)
- 11 The infamy of having it in for me? (3)
- 12 Historic King starting lunch (non-vegetarian) (5)
- 13 Gifts, though some are only on loan (7)
- 15 The man's property in Chislehurst (3)

- 21 Just what you'd expect from a phoney hoodlum (9)
- 23 Fire down below (4)
- 24 Rests, and turns back for the bridge (4)
- 26 The way to start work on a house (3)
- 27 It's taken very seriously (4)
- 29 A political label, in short, can be deceptive (4)
- 32 The rotters gas for about half an hour! (4)
- 33 Tease a thick-headed relative (5)
- 34 He didn't rule the waves (6)
- 35 History-making game? (8)
- 36 Groups causing near chaos at some stage? (6)

- 16 Might such gloves suit a boxer? (3)
- 18 Trying one's hardest to get the team dismissed (3,3)
- 20 Bad actors have no right to be in operal
- 21 There aren't many in a cafe, washing up
- 22 A breathy palindrome (3)
- 23 For keys in the house, this must be paid
- 25 A hostel in the heart of Colindale (3)
- 28 Wherein to fight a hard-hearted woman
- 30 New route, like a ring road? (5)
- 31 Turning a person to rock! (5)
- 32 Clever and pretty attractive (4)
- 33 Drank excessively at the King's Head (4)

Odisha Governor inaugurates NBCC solar plant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

In a significant step towards promoting renewable energy and sustainable development, Odisha Governor Hari Babu Kambhampati inaugurated a 485 kWp Rooftop Solar Photovoltaic (PV) Power Plant at Lok Bhavan, Bhubaneswar, developed and executed by NBCC (India) Limited. The inauguration was held in the presence of Dr. KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC, and JP Guru, SBG, Odisha, NBCC.

The solar project, spread across approximately 39,000 sq. ft within the Lok Bhavan campus, has been installed across eight locations, including the Governor House Building, Administrative Building, Abhishek Banquet Hall, Energy Park, etc. Equipped with advanced solar technology, the installation is expected to generate nearly 60,000 units of clean electricity every month, significantly reducing con-



ventional energy consumption and carbon emissions. Keeping in mind the current energy shortage owing to the West Asia conflict, the need to promote renewable energy usage is of great significance. EV vehicles can also be charged owing to the installation of the solar plant. NBCC stands committed to working on promoting the usage of renewable energy and shall also be working on wind energy generation as a part of its endeavour to boost India's energy security.

The project reflects NBCC's

commitment to supporting India's clean energy transition and creating environmentally sustainable public infrastructure. The initiative is expected to contribute substantially towards reducing the carbon footprint of the Lok Bhavan complex while serving as a model for renewable energy adoption in government establishments.

As a leading public sector construction and project management company, NBCC has consistently incorporated sustainable features

such as solar energy systems, rainwater harvesting, wastewater recycling and energy-efficient technologies in its major projects which are GRIHA or IGBC certified.

Odisha remains one of NBCC's key focus states. Over the years, the company has executed/executing several prestigious projects in the state, including IIT Bhubaneswar, IIM Sambalpur, National Law University Cuttack, Ravenshaw University, Central University of Odisha, Ispat Post Graduate Institute & Super Speciality Hospital, Rourkela, Pabitra Mohan Pradhan Medical College & Hospital, Talcher, Skill Development Institute Khordha, and numerous healthcare, tourism and urban infrastructure projects.

These projects have strengthened educational, healthcare and civic infrastructure across the state while generating employment opportunities and contributing to economic growth.

Shah to launch Land Port Management System

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Amit Shah will launch the Land Port Management System (LPMS) on Tuesday in New Delhi. This initiative underscores the Modi Government's commitment to smart border management, enhancing efficiency, transparency, and security in cross-border trade and passenger movement through technology-driven solutions.

On this occasion, the Union Home Minister will also inaugurate newly devel-



oped stakeholder accommodation facilities at the Dawki (Meghalaya) and Srimantapur (Tripura) land ports, further reinforcing

infrastructure support for border security personnel and other valuable stakeholders.

The launch of LPMS will be

a landmark step in India's journey towards a modern, technology-enabled smart border management system, reflecting the nation's strategic focus on strengthening trade facilitation, connectivity, and national security and Viksit Bharat by 2047.

LPMS is a state-of-the-art digital platform designed to integrate operations across land ports into a unified system. It enables secure, real-time exchange of logistics and regulatory information, bringing land ports at par with digital systems operational at airports and seaports.

 BRIEFLY

Animesh wins silver in 200m in Taipei City Athletics Open



National record holder Animesh Kujur finished second in the men's 200m with the fourth fastest time of his career at the New Taipei City Athletics Open 2026 on Sunday. The 23-year-old Indian, whose national record stands at 20.32 seconds, clocked a solid 20.47seconds. Animesh has also run 20.40 seconds and 20.45 seconds last year, and thus his effort on Sunday was his fourth fastest time. Thailand's Puripol Boonson ran a lifetime best of 20.03 seconds to finish on top and become the joint third-fastest Asian man of all time over the 200m. On Saturday, long jumper Shaili Singh and the women's 4x100m relay team won a gold medal each, while Tejas Shirse bagged a silver in the 110m hurdles.

ABVP delegation meets Mansukh Mandaviya over 2036 Olympics



An Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) delegation met Union Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya and submitted a memorandum suggesting measures to strengthen sports culture, athlete welfare and India's preparations for the 2036 Olympics, the RSS youth wing said on Sunday. Accepting the proposal for the construction of an Olympic-standard synthetic athletic track at Panjab University, Mandaviya said that progress on the proposed track is expected within the next two to three months, the ABVP said in a statement. Led by Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad National General Secretary Virendra Singh Solanki, the delegation proposed establishing sports universities in every state and centres of excellence and multi-sports complexes in every district. Among several other recommendations, the student body also proposed talent identification initiatives in rural and tribal areas, health and accident insurance for athletes, sports equipment banks, the launch of a national digital athlete portal, and an increase in the honorarium for MY Bharat volunteers, a statement said.

Ahlawat struggles in third round of Swiss Challenge

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucerne (Switzerland)

After setting a course record in the second round, Veer Ahlawat could not sustain the momentum, dropping 12 positions to tied 13th after the third round at the Swiss Challenge at Golf Sempach. Ahlawat carded a 3-over 74 to be 9-under par after three rounds. He was six shots behind the leader, George Bloor (67), who was heading into the final round with a total score of 15-under par. Ahlawat began his third round with early birdies on the first and fourth holes before dropping a shot on the fifth. He would pick up the stroke on the sixth before dropping two shots on the seventh



with his first double bogey of the day. He followed it with his second bogey on the eighth hole. On the back nine, Ahlawat dropped a second double on the 15th before picking up one shot on the 17th hole, only to give it back with a bogey on the 18th. Ahlawat, who has yet to win a title on the Hotel Planner Tour, will need to find the magic from his second round once more if he hopes to challenge for the title this week. Bloor carded a round of 4-under 67 to become the sole leader heading into the final round. Bloor is one stroke clear of Hamish Brown and Matthew Southgate. The third round by Bloor included five birdies and one bogey.

United States feeling confident going into World Cup off tight loss against Germany

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Chicago

Antonee Robinson struck the ball perfectly with his left foot, and it rocketed into the corner of the goal. Surrounded by a delirious sellout crowd at Soldier Field, the defender celebrated with a cartwheel and a backflip. Not a bad way to go into the World Cup. Robinson's spectacular goal was the biggest highlight for the United States in a 2-1 loss to Germany on Saturday. It was the ninth consecutive loss for the U.S. against European opponents dating to 2022, but the Americans were encouraged by their performance in their final World Cup tuneup. "I mean, against a really

good team, I thought we were dangerous at times," forward Christian Pulisic said. "We had good stretches of possession, defended well for good portions of it. And, yeah, I mean, honestly, I think, we're feeling good." Members of the 1994 U.S. team were recognised on the field before the game. Coach Mauricio Pochettino started what figures to be close to his World Cup lineup, with Matt Freese in goal, Sergino Dest at right back, Alex Freeman, Miles Robinson and Tim Ream in central defence, Antonee Robinson at left back, Tyler Adams and Malik Tillman in defensive midfield, Pulisic and Weston McKennie in advanced midfield and

Pragg is more dangerous than Carlsen: Thipsay

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

First Indian to win the prestigious Norway Chess title, Rameshbabu Praggananandhaa is a more dangerous player than even World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen and the most improved chess player in the world, according to Arjuna awardee Grandmaster Pravin Thipsay. Praggananandhaa's historic triumph at Norway Chess 2026 has reinforced his status among the game's elite, with Thipsay rating him as India's strongest player at present, ahead of reigning world champion D. Gukesh and Arjun Erigaisi. "Praggananandhaa is the best Indian chess player right

now. On current form, he can be considered one of the most dangerous opponents in the world, even more dangerous than Carlsen," Thipsay told PTI in an interview. He pointed to Praggananandhaa's impressive record against the Norwegian legend, noting that few players have enjoyed such success against Carlsen in recent years. Thipsay described the Norway Chess victory as one of the finest achievements by an Indian player in recent years. He particularly praised Praggananandhaa's finish to the tournament, where he won his final four rounds against opponents rated above 2750, including Carlsen



and Gukesh. "What a great comeback. After a somewhat disappointing 2025, he has produced something truly extraordinary. Indian chess needed a performance like this," he said. According to Thipsay, the 20-year-old's

biggest achievement has been the transformation of his playing style. Once known primarily as a sharp attacking player who relied heavily on opening preparation, Praggananandhaa has developed into a far more versatile competitor capable of excelling in a variety of positions. "Three or four years ago, he was feared for his attacking chess. But opponents gradually learned how to neutralise those strengths. Over the last few months, he has added new dimensions to his game, including improved defence, positional understanding and tactical accuracy," Thipsay explained. He compared the evolution

of Praggananandhaa's style to that of former world champion Anatoly Karpov and Carlsen, players who focus less on gaining opening advantages and more on gradually outplaying opponents through superior understanding and consistency. Thipsay believes India currently possesses three genuine world-title contenders in Praggananandhaa, Gukesh and Arjun Erigaisi. While all three are capable of becoming world champions, he feels Praggananandhaa holds a slight edge at present because of his recent form and ability to consistently defeat players of equal or greater strength. (PTI)

Andreeva says she had to overcome so many demons inside to win French Open

ANDREW DAMPF ■ Paris

Bent over with her hands covering her face, her knees getting dirtied on the red clay court, Mirra Andreeva was celebrating — processing might be the more appropriate word — how she had finally overcome "so many demons inside" that came with being a teenage tennis phenom. After bursting onto the scene at 15, Andreeva became a Grand Slam champion at 19 when the Russian ended the run of 114th-ranked Polish qualifier Maja Chwalinska with a 6-3, 6-2 victory in the French Open final on Saturday.



"I've done a lot of visualisations before. Not just this tournament, but I've had dreams, I've had a lot of thoughts on how it's going to happen, if it's going to

happen, when it's going to happen, where," Andreeva said, still hardly breathing as she talked quickly in true teenage style. "The feeling in real life is so much better

than in your dreams. "I can call myself a Grand Slam champion," Andreeva added. The biggest challenges for Andreeva have not been on the court — she already has one of the best attacking baseline games in the sport — it's been the mental side. And her stubbornness. "Her attitude is difficult," said Conchita Martinez, Andreeva's coach and a former Wimbledon champion. "You tell her something, and maybe she's not open to listening. When she works hard and when she listens and she does everything, she has no limits." (AP)

Kochhar stays in top 10 at IGPL Bharath Classic

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ El Jadida (Morocco)

Karandeep Kochhar remained the best-placed Indian at the IGPL Bharath Classic despite slipping to tied 10th after a third-round 2-under 70 in challenging windy conditions. The 27-year-old from Chandigarh moved to 7-under for the tournament but dropped from overnight tied fifth as Thailand's Settee Prakongvech surged into a three-shot lead at 13-under with a bogey-free 68. Overnight joint leaders Runchanapong Youprayong (71) and Sweden's Charlie Lindh (67) were tied second at 10-under. Searching for his maiden Asian Tour title, Kochhar endured a frustrating day of missed opportunities. He birdied the third and sixth, dropped a shot on the 13th and picked up another birdie on the 16th for a round of 70. "Still, a good day. I hung in there and scrambled well, but didn't create enough birdie chances. I had good



looks on 15, 17 and 18 that just missed," said Kochhar, who has already posted two top-five finishes on the Asian Tour this season. "I'm 10th now and need to push harder tomorrow to finish higher and end the week on a good note." Among the other Indians, Gaganjeet

Singh Bhullar and Pukhraj Singh Gill carded 69s to climb to tied 36th. Kartik Singh, who shared fifth place overnight, slipped to tied 36th after a 75. Yashas Chandra (71), Raghav Chugh (70) and Rashid Khan (69) were also tied 36th, while Shaurya Bhattacharya was tied 49th after a 72.

Nayanika Sanga lead Indian golfer in Arkea Ladies Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Montauban (France)

Nayanika Sanga played her second successive even par round to be the lead Indian golfer after the second of the Arkea Montauban Ladies Open on the LET Access Series. Starting the day on T-21 at Golf de Montauban, Nayanika played herself into the top 20 with one round left to play. She is now T-18 with an even par score. Saanvi Somu (72-73) is the other Indian player in the field. She carded 1-over 73 to drop six places and find herself in T-27. Saanvi has a total score



of 1-over par after two rounds. She made two bogeys and one birdie in her second round. Genevieve Ling, Sarah Skovgaard Bils, Marine Griffaut and Lucie Malchirand shared the lead

heading into the final round with a score of 6-under par. Nayanika Sanga had an early bogey on her second round on the second hole before she recovered the shot with a birdie on the seventh hole.

IGU names six-member team for Asian Games in Japan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Yuvraj Sandhu and Aditi Ashok were among a six-member Indian golf team named on Sunday for the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, later this year. A LPGA Tour regular, Aditi won an individual silver medal in the 2022 Asian Games in Hangzhou, China. Sandhu (World No. 451), Veer Ahlawat (World No. 558) and Saptak Talwar (World No. 576) are the three male



members, while Aditi (World No. 135), Diksha Dagar (World No. 221) and Pranavi Urs (World No. 270) are the three female players named by the Indian Golf Union (IGU). The golf events for both men and women are scheduled from September 30 to October 3 at the Kasugai Country Club East Course. The IGU, led by Brijinder Singh, said the entries were decided as per its selection policy for the Asian Games. "We have got a supremely talented and efficient squad, which has someone like Yuvraj Sandhu, who won seven times on the PGTI circuit last year," Singh said in a release.

Suthar brilliant on debut as India take control against Afghanistan

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ Mullanpur

Debutant Manav Suthar's classical left-arm spin bowling was a beacon of hope for a bright future as his three wickets gave India complete control on the second day of their one-off Test against Afghanistan here on Sunday.

With mercury soaring, India declared their first innings at 564 for 8 once Washington Sundar scored a pressure-free half-century while adding 54 useful runs with Suthar (28 off 41 balls).

At stumps, Afghanistan were tottering at 113 for 5 with Suthar recording figures of 3 for 21 in 15.5 overs.

Prasidh Krishna (2/27 in 7

overs) was the other wicket-taker. Hosts, now, are ahead by 451 runs.

Having warmed up nicely with a short yet sweet maiden Test knock, Suthar got into the act straightway after being summoned to bowl the last over before tea. He removed opener Abdul Malik, who wanted to sweep his way out of trouble after looking clueless facing first three deliveries.

A classical action and the old school diagonal run-up of bowling to right-handers while cutting between the umpire and stumps, the 23-year-old from Rajasthan's Sri Ganganagar was a delight to watch.

In times when spin bowling



India's Manav Suthar bowls on day two of a Test cricket match between India and Afghanistan, in Mullanpur on Sunday.

extra bounce forcing batters to go on back-foot, and a few others were classic arm balls that come in with the angle. The wicket of the

In the case of Rahmanullah Gurbaz, a former KKR opening batter, he simply didn't allow him to come on the front-foot.

He bowled a few that went straight and Gurbaz defended. Then from the same spot, he bowled one that dipped late and then turned away kissing the edge of Gurbaz's willow into Sai Sudharsan's hands in the second slip.

Suthar's third and final wicket of the day came when the ball stopped and bounced with Afsar Zazai closing the face of the bat and the loopy leading edge resulted in an easy return catch.

Skipper Shubman Gill, very rightly allowed him to bowl unchanged for 13 overs from one end while shuffling

between Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh and Kuldeep Yadav at the other end.

If Suthar's impressive initiation into Test arena is any indication, Indian selectors can hope for a smooth transition as and when Ravindra Jadeja is phased out from red ball format.

Earlier, Rishabh Pant answered his critics in the best possible manner with a stroke-filled 81 while Afghanistan pacer Mohammad Saleem enjoyed the fruits of labour in punishing weather with figures of 6 for 140. In front of a sparse Sunday crowd, Pant did play his signature strokes but also curbed his natural instinct to go after each delivery, treating each

ball on its merit during his 121-ball knock that had six boundaries and three sixes. He should have completed his century but off-spinner Hashmatullah Shahidi slowed the pace considerably. Pant charged down the track but couldn't fully reach to the pitch of the delivery as the lofted hit ballooned up for a simple catch for Azmatullah Omarzai. For Afghanistan, their IPL star Omarzai was distinctly unlucky. He was impressive with the second new ball, beating the bat on a number of occasions without much luck. In fact, Pant, like KL Rahul did on Day 1, also edged one but no one from the Afghanistan team appealed for caught behind.

Tilak, Siraj get big bids in TG20 player auction

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

India's T20 vice-captain Tilak Varma fetched the highest bid of Rs 33 lakh from Medak Falcons at the inaugural TG20 player auction here on Sunday. Tilak was appointed on Saturday as the vice-captain of India's squads that will tour Ireland and England for five T20Is, which will be led by Shreyas Iyer.

Tilak's India teammate Mohammed Siraj joined the Warangal Warriors. The Warriors picked up the pacer for ₹14 lakh.

Both Tilak and Siraj were Icon Class players, while there were other categories



such as A+ and A.

All-rounder CV Milind became the most expensive uncapped player, with Anvita Khammam Aces securing him for ₹17 lakh.

The inaugural TG20 will commence on June 21 at the Rajiv Gandhi International Cricket Stadium, Uppal, with eight franchises competing in 32 matches over 21 days.

BCCI lets Sooryavanshi's parents accompany him on overseas tours

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, who broke into the national team, thereby becoming the youngest cricket player to play for India, will not miss his parents. They will accompany him on the overseas tours of Sri Lanka and England in the next few weeks.

Given his age, 15 years and 71 days to be precise, the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) has requested his parents to travel with Team India as



the wonder kid assimilates into the demanding world of international cricket along with adults. The board's request came right after the national selec-

tors called up Vaibhav to the T20I team on Saturday. Reports also said the BCCI will bear the expenses of Vaibhav's parents. The BCCI made special provisions for young Vaibhav, who will be assimilating into an adult squad for the first time in his career. The youngster could become the youngest debutant ever for India, surpassing the record held by Sachin Tendulkar, who made his debut at 16 years and 207 days.

BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia said that while the board does not usually

allow parents to accompany players on tours, special permission was given to Vaibhav and his family as India tries to bring a special talent into the national fold.

"He was selected to go with the senior team from the India A team to Sri Lanka. As he is a small child, he is still a minor. When he is travelling with the men's team, who are all adults, therefore, we deem it proper that his parents or anybody from the family can travel with him to Sri Lanka," Saikia told the media.

I don't have to change my personality: Shreyas



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

India's T20I skipper Shreyas Iyer on Sunday said he has always loved facing challenges growing up, and the new responsibility of leading the country in the shortest format doesn't mean he has to change his personality.

The 31-year-old Iyer was named the captain of the Indian T20I side, replacing Suryakumar Yadav, who had led the national team to the T20 World Cup title in March.

Iyer said he would want to remain the same person who grew up in a challenging cricket environment in Mumbai. "I don't have to change my personality. I have to be the same person I was before, and not try to be someone else or be under someone's shadow," Iyer said at an event here. "I obviously loved challenges growing up, especially being from Mumbai, where cricket is pretty big, and competition is high. Every other kid on the street they want to represent Mumbai."

He said his mindset was always about winning against everyone that he challenged. "My mindset was always

about winning, against everyone that I challenged, so whether it's about learning or winning, that is secondary, but the more fun you have growing up, the more competitive nature you have, especially while you play cricket or any other sport in general," said Iyer. "I think that takes you to another level and you want to take that sort of responsibility (and) even when I've got this job right now, or a responsibility as a captain, it's a great challenge at the same time," he said.

Meanwhile, former India captain Sourav Ganguly said Iyer has earned the role of national team captaincy. Iyer, who is set to lead India in Ireland for two T20Is as his first assignment as skipper, had played the last of his 51 T20Is in December 2023 before losing his spot. The right-handed batter comes into the side and the middle-order as a like-for-like replacement of former skipper Suryakumar Yadav, who was also dropped from Indian squad. "Shreyas has done well; he has earned it. I would not say that removal of Suryakumar Yadav is unfair. The selectors have made a decision," Ganguly said.

It's dream come true; hard work in domestic cricket paid off: Suthar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

It's a dream come true for youngster Manav Suthar to earn a maiden India call-up for the one-off Test against Afghanistan after learning the ropes through street cricket and ignoring constant discouragement from people not to pick the game as a career option.

The 23-year-old left-arm spin-bowling all-rounder from Rajasthan, however, never deviated from the path he had chosen, and he credited his consistent performances in domestic cricket and for India A for his maiden India call-up.

"Cricket has always been a big part of my family. My father loves the game, and everyone at home watches

matches regularly. As a young boy, I used to sit with them and watch. That is where my love for cricket first started. I began playing in the streets with my friends. Those street games taught me the basics, how to hold the bat and how to bowl," Suthar said on 'JioStar'.

"When I was 10 or 11, I joined a proper cricket academy. I started training under Coach Dheeraj sir and Vinod sir. They taught me the right techniques and helped me improve my game.

"My first big breakthrough came when I played for Rajasthan in the Under-14 category. That experience gave me a lot of motivation. I realised that I could make a career out of this sport. From there, my journey as a cricketer truly began."



On the obstacles he overcame to make it to the top level, the youngster said, "In a country like India, with such a huge population, succeeding in cricket is never easy. There are so many talented players competing for the same few spots. I faced a lot of challenges along the

way. Many people told me to focus on my studies. They said cricket had no scope and that I was wasting my time. "But I didn't listen. I didn't give up. I kept working hard, session after session, season after season. I had a great domestic season. I performed well for India A, too.

I knew the call could come anytime. It was a waiting game, but I stayed patient."

Suthar has been a prolific wicket-taker since the 2022-23 Ranji Trophy, where he had 39 scalps in six matches.

He has been a regular in the India Emerging and India A squads. In just three Ranji matches he played in 2025-26, he picked up 18 wickets, including a match-winning 8 for 42 against Chhattisgarh.

Overall, Suthar has taken 129 wickets in 29 first-class games, along with a century and six half-centuries.

He made his IPL debut in 2024 with the Gujarat Titans but played just one game that season. He didn't get a chance to play in 2025, but featured in four games in 2026. "It felt good to be back on the field. Now, all the hard

work in domestic cricket and for India A has paid off. Making my international debut, it is a dream come true. All the sacrifices have finally paid off. I feel proud, grateful, and ready to give my best for the country."

He said everyone in his family was emotional when he got the news of his Test selection. "I was in my room when my sister called me. She told me that my name had come up in the Indian team. I asked her if it was official. She said 'yes'. Everyone was emotional when I got the call. "Dad, Mom, everyone called me. They couldn't believe it. I can't describe it in words. It's the biggest feeling. You work hard for years, and then you finally get selected for India. It's the best feeling of my life."

AI-powered Kabuni launches platform to make cricket coaching accessible

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

AI-powered sports technology platform Kabuni on Sunday launched a global cricket coaching platform aimed at making elite-level training accessible to players of all backgrounds through real-time, personalised feedback.

Unveiled at the company's Playtime 2026 event in Mumbai, the platform uses its proprietary Kabuni PlayOS technology to analyse live play and assess key aspects such as timing, balance, footwork and alignment, providing instant coaching insights that were previously available only at elite academies.



The company said the platform's goal is to place a "world-class cricket coach in every player's pocket" and encourage young people to spend more time playing sport and less time on passive

screen activities.

Kabuni has also signed a group of celebrated cricketers, including Sourav Ganguly, Shane Watson, AB de Villiers and Shreyas Iyer, as its "Super Coaches".

‘We were superstitious, didn't come to watch second day's play’

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ Mullanpur

Jagdish Suthar, a retired Physical Education teacher from Rajasthan's Sri Ganganagar district, had travelled all the way to Mullanpur with his family to watch his elder child Manav make his Test debut for India, but left for home without watching his son's on-field exploits on the second day of the match against Afghanistan on Sunday.

Suthar made a brilliant debut as he had the Afghanistan batters tied in knots with figures of 3 for 21 in 15.5 overs.

"Yes, my wife, my daughter, and Mansi (Manav's younger sister) had come to

watch his debut. I can't describe how it felt seeing him get the Test Cap yesterday. However, today we had come back home as we were all nervous and a bit superstitious watching him live in action from the stadium," the soft-spoken Jagdish Suthar told PTI during an exclusive interaction on the second day of the Test.

A man of few words, Jagdish was very reluctant to take any credit for his son's success on the cricket field, which has now culminated in donning the national colours. "It is completely Manav's hard work and the hours that he has put into practice. He would leave home for training in the morning and return late in



the evening. It is his credit and his childhood coach, Dheeraj Sharma, to whom we are all indebted. Manav learnt all his cricket under him," Suthar senior said. Asked when did he actually found that his son has talent,

the father said that it wasn't like one fine day that he realised it.

"Like every other child, he was also passionate about cricket. He would play with tennis and a rubber ball when he was around six to

seven years old. Since I was a PT teacher, I always encouraged my son to play the sport and enjoy it. When he was around 10 to 11 years old, I had enrolled him in Dheeraj Sir's academy.

After that, I just told him, "Tujhe jo accha lage, tu kar, mera support humesha tere saath rahega (Whatever you feel like pursuing, do it, and I will give you my full support, Jagdish added. Asked if he was concerned about his son's studies, he replied in the negative. "Cricket was his focus, but he has also completed his graduation," he informed. According to the father, the son is a very reticent and seldom speaks about cricket when he is at home.

Second West Indies-Sri Lanka ODI washed out

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kingston

The second one-day cricket international between the West Indies and Sri Lanka has been abandoned because of rain without a ball being bowled.

Sri Lanka leads the three-match series 1-0 after winning the first match on Thursday by 41 runs, giving former Proteas star Gary



Kirsten his first win as Sri Lanka coach and the tourists' first ODI win in the Caribbean in 13 years.

England's Bazball reset begins with win over New Zealand

STEVE DOUGLAS
■ London

England wrapped up a 115-run victory over New Zealand before lunch on Day 4 of the first cricket Test at Lord's on Sunday, marking a positive start to its "Bazball" reset after the Ashes humiliation Down Under.

Resuming on 55-5 and requiring 254 for an unlikely win, New Zealand lost its remaining five wickets inside the first two hours of play



and was dismissed for 138. England pacer Gus Atkinson finished with team-best figures of 5-30 on a

challenging, bowler-friendly surface at the home of cricket that saw 24 batters out bowled or lbw.

It was fitting that the match ended with the middle stump flattened after Atkinson clean-bowled Kiwi tail-ender, Matt Henry. That left Glenn Phillips stranded at the other end on 44 not out, making him New Zealand's top scorer of a disappointing test for the tourists.

"You've got to play what's in front of you, you've got to

identify the conditions as a team and understand what you think is the best way for you to go out there and win," England captain Ben Stokes said of the conditions in a match that lasted just 166 overs. "And we did that better than New Zealand this week." This first test series of the summer has been regarded as a fresh start for England and its under-pressure leadership after a 4-1 loss to Australia during an Ashes tour featur-

ing reports of excessive drinking and when England was accused of slack preparation and a wrong tactical approach.

The headline selections early in this second iteration of "Bazball" under coach Brendon McCullum and Stokes were opener Emilio Gay and seam bowler Ollie Robinson - and both delivered. With a second-innings 57, Gay had the highest individual score from either team on his test debut.